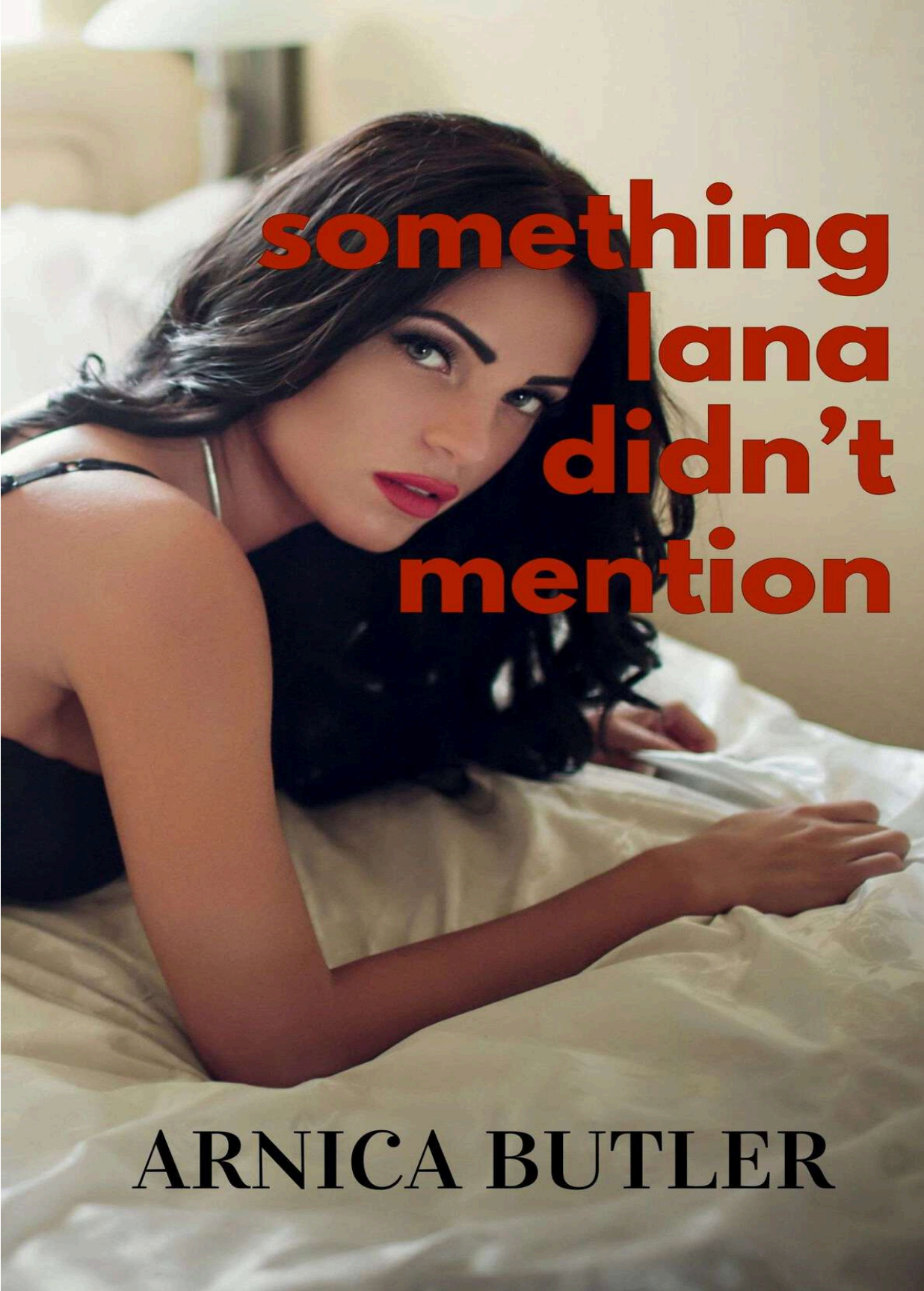


A woman with long, dark, wavy hair and bright pink lipstick is lying on her stomach on a bed with white linens. She is looking directly at the camera with a slight smile. The background is softly blurred, showing a lamp and a headboard.

**something
lana
didn't
mention**

ARNICA BUTLER

A woman with long, dark, wavy hair is lying in bed, propped up on her left arm. She is wearing a black strapless top and looking directly at the camera with a slight smile. The bed has white linens. The background is a softly lit room with a lamp visible in the upper left.

**something
lana
didn't
mention**

ARNICA BUTLER

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Chapter One

Seven months ago, I was a man in full.

I had a new job. I was making good money. I owned a house in a nice suburban neighborhood that Lana Cuervo - who wanted children and whom I wanted very much to impregnate - had chosen based on its proximity to good schools and low crime rate. I mowed the lawn and approved all curtain choices, emulating true concern about the differences between "Potter's Gray" and "Oakland Gray," even though I couldn't tell the difference and suspected no one on Earth could, either.

Why did I feign interest in throw pillows and Ruggables? Because Lana Cuervo was my dream woman, and I was done for the moment I turned around in a bar and poured a margarita all over her. Big, sexy lips in the shape of a heart; a doll's upturned nose, dark eyes behind the longest, thickest lashes I'd ever seen. Her hair was dark, straight and shiny, and her almond skin was smooth as glass.

You'd think with a name like Lana Cuervo, I'd have found her in a vampy, skin-tight red dress. One that showed off her pert breasts and the lethally beautiful curve of her ass. But Lana was a "cute" girl with a too-sexy name. Lana was a name that gave her a faint aura of the exotic and taboo, but none of that was actually there. When I dumped the margarita on her, she was dressed in a conservative lilac-colored t-shirt, neutrally tight jeans, and a business-like ponytail, and that's the sort of thing my wife always wears.

Wore.

I came home every day to Lana Cuervo - yes, her real, maiden name - and stared at her while she puttered around the kitchen. Somehow, I had convinced this woman to marry me.

We had a wedding at a huge venue that my WASPy family was probably horrified by, full of Lana's boisterous Mexican relatives. We went to Cancun for our honeymoon. We had good jobs. We had a brilliant sex life that went a little stale during the pandemic, but bounced back. As much as it can when you've been married for five years, anyway.

Lana was a sweet, bubbly, very pretty wife, and again: I worshiped her from the moment I poured that margarita on her.

Lana was a pretty buttoned-down girl, something I attributed to her Mexican heritage and conservative father. I *liked* that he had obviously kept Lana locked down: there were boyfriends in her past that he didn't approve of at all, he told me, as if he'd glared them all away into oblivion. (Believe me, the man could do it). I liked this about Lana.

I even liked my new job.

I even liked the new boss, who showed up two days after I got hired.

My boss was a cool guy who kind of reminded me of my buddy Jake. Athletic, good-looking, leader-of-men-type shit through and through.

I say "kind of" reminded me of Jake because this guy was a little rougher around the edges. More alpha than team captain. But I work in finance, and under him, in hedge funds. That's what you want in that business: a rough and cultured, alpha male.

This guy. His name is fucking Dominic Kane. He has black hair and blue eyes and makes people piss themselves, staring out of his big glass office windows. He always looks peeved. He crushes people on the phone. He could sell you on eating your own shit and thanking him for the opportunity.

He could, but he usually doesn't.

Mostly, he just makes us all a lot of money and brings in heavy-hitters, takes enormous risks and never sweats them.

The rest of the time he's fairly affable. He goes by Nick, for fuck's sake.

So this is where the story begins. Me, and my wife, and my big house, and my aspirations to keep said wife happy.

"Guess what?" I asked Lana, who was making a Hello Fresh dinner and adding dangerous looking peppers to it by the handful.

"Is it work related?" she asked me, smiling. She had latex gloves on, because I discovered the hard way that having a really hot half-Mexican wife carries some risk of unfortunate accidents involving your dick and jalapenos.

That's a pro tip that I suggest you take to the bank.

"Sort of," I admitted. What wasn't, when you work in finance?

She raised her eyebrows. "The new boss invited you to go golfing," she suggested.

"No," I told her, peering into the pan as an excuse to put my hands on her hips and also determine how many Tums I was going to need. There was no talking this woman out of peppers. She had cut down for me, but Lana's version of "mild" food involved only using three peppers instead of thirty. "Better than golf."

"Ooooooh," Lana said, with commendable faux interest. "To his *yacht*, then."

Lana didn't think much of the finance sector alpha bros.

She wanted me to get out of hedge funds and work in a less - in her words- testosterone-fueled, alpha-cosplay environment, like a bank or mutual funds. And I had been about to do just that, but the job I landed was too good to turn down.

I needed the money. I needed the testosterone boost. I wasn't good enough for Lana all by myself. If Lana had wanted to, she could have put on tight dresses and bikinis and landed herself a billionaire. *Ora mafia don.*

She didn't, and for whatever reason, she married me. But I wasn't dumb enough to think I could sit on my ass and manage mutual funds carefully for some middling salary and hold on to Lana. The wolves were always, always at the door.

Every single man turned his head or at least his eyes to check her out. Lana didn't dress overly sexy, or flirt, or do much to attract attention. But she was so pretty, with such a big smile, and her ass was impossible for men to ignore. She had long legs, and if she wore shorts, they all looked tiny compared to the stretches of smooth, toasted skin that poured from them and swished around gracefully down to her sensible shoes.

I was a boring man, with a forgettable face and average mojo.

If I am being honest, it made my dick hard thinking about other men sniffing around Lana. Men looked at us together and I could pretty much

pick the thoughts out of their heads: *that guy must have a huge dick or filthy money.*

I didn't have either, but with Lana on my arm? It looked like I did.

"He isn't a yacht or golf guy," I told her, for what seemed like the hundredth time. "He's more of an ex-"

"He's an *extreme sports performance machine*," Lana sang, saying "extreme sports performance" with a deeply sarcastic, masculine, "announcer" voice.

She set a towel on the counter and smiled, radiantly. "How *original*. So where is he taking you? Base jumping?" She opened her eyes wide, alarmed. "He's not a hockey guy, is he?"

Lana is, to put it mildly, unimpressed by hockey. She doesn't even know how to skate and she's not about to try, even for rom-com value. (I tried).

She hates the smell of stale ice and sweat, and she hates the injuries. I broke my collarbone two years before this, and she hated it all the more after that. She'll put on her game face and go to a game or watch it on TV, and she endearingly learned the rules and can muster a passable impression of interest.

It's a young man's game anyway, so this didn't bother me that much: in fact, having Lana as an excuse to bow out of Jake's overly-rough league was a blessing.

Jake could understand pussy-whipped.

He could not understand pussying out, due to age of all things. Jake has no front teeth and he doesn't listen to whining from anyone who does.

"You are going to like this," I told her, very pleased to be telling her. I sat down and dipped a corn chip into some salsa that I could see I was going to regret. It was a rusty orange color, which signaled extreme danger.

Some people make salsa. Lana makes habanero purees.

"I was telling him that my wife is Latina -"

"Latin-equis, you meant." Lana grinned peevishly.

Lana speaks pretty fluent Spanish, but it is, she notes all the time, "mostly about food and diapers, or telling people where to go." Her temper, which is mild, flares into an inferno of rage any time she sees "Latinx" in a newspaper. She has canceled subscriptions, personally and on the phone, to over a dozen publications because of this word.

What makes her so mad?

"It's unpronounceable. And it's stupid. What's next? *Hola, carin-equis, me prestas el carr-equis para ir al supermercad-equis? Idiot-equis-es. Caraj-equis.*"

I don't have any idea what any of that means. I stay out of the way about this and agree with whatever she says.

"...and it turns out, *he* has a girlfriend who is always trying to drag him to salsa dancing," I finished, carefully, once I could see she wasn't going to go on more of a rampage. Which happens. Lana is very, very opinionated about "Latinx" and not much else in the political realm at all.

Lana blinked at me. Annoyance fluttered at the edges of her very long eyelashes and compressed her lips into a bleak line. "*I'm* always trying to drag you to salsa dancing."

This salsa, the sauce, was hot enough to kill me. I sucked air over it and tried not sweat under my eyes.

"I knoh. So geh thohs." I took a pause to air out my mouth, making Lana shake her head a little ("It doesn't *do* anything!" she was always insisting) "He said: let's all go together. Meaning you and me. Us. And the girlfriend."

I never know which way Lana is going to go on anything. It's what I love most about her. Sure, she's cute as a bunny and sweet and delicious as deep-fried ice cream, but she's a shifting wind about a lot of things.

She made her funny frown-face - an indicator of surprise at being wrong about something - and wiped something off the table. She shrugged.

"Huh. Maybe New-Boss isn't that bad."

"Really?" I opened my mouth again and fanned it.

"Why did you *eat* that?"

For you, I wanted to scream. *Everything stupid I do is for you.*

I said, however: "Are you really going to go?"

She leaned on the counter and rested on her elbows, drawing me close to her mouth with a crooked finger. I leaned in.

One doesn't turn down Lana Cuervo-Robertson's mouth.

"Tell me this: Is his girlfriend old enough to get in a club?"

"*Lana*," I began.

Lana had never met Nick. She didn't even remember his name, as far as I knew. She called him "New Boss" or "Performance Man."

She had built up a whole world in her head, in which Nick was every finance guy in an eighties movie and had underage girlfriends, yachts, golf

memberships and six ex-wives. She made fun of me -gently - every time I told her about something he'd done.

But Lana was also a supportive wife. Somewhere deep down inside she understood that I wanted my job for her, and she understood that I had to get in good with the boss.

She smiled, twisting playfully as she inched closer to me over the counter, and licked my upper lip. "Okay," she said. "I'm game."

She went back to cooking dinner, and I fanned my mouth and stared at her ass, turned on by the lick on my lip and the pleasing way she'd twisted and smiled, flirtatious only for me, on approach.

Lana's ass could be a whole story in and of itself. Who knows where it came from? Her mother was a flat-assed woman of Russian and third-generation German descent. Lana's was high and rounded, pleasingly shaped from all angles.

Lana's ass is so terrific that I was prepared to go to whatever kind of dancing Lana wanted to go to. With whoever was going to be there. It didn't matter.

If it made Lana happy, and kept her in my house making tacos and letting me grab that bounty when I walked by, it was fine with me.

Sign me up.

I have a strange relationship with my worries about Lana and other men. On the one hand, I obviously want to keep Lana for myself. I worship Lana.

On the other hand, I am a guy. I like competition, and I like status. Having a woman like Lana on my arm introduces healthy proportions of both into my life.

So as we were walking into *La Cabana*, I was of two minds.

Lana was wearing a red dress.

This was no slinky, low-cut, high-hem dress. It had no sleeves, which was pretty risqué for Lana, and the neck dipped a little. The skirt was loose and would, presumably, flare out when she spun. Only then would it lift to give a view of her thighs; as she walked it was frustratingly loose, tantalizing with brief glimpses of the shape of her butt, but never revealing the whole picture. She had heels on, but they were sensible. Her hair was in slightly

fancier pony-tail than the one I'd met her in, with a few tendrils cascading to her shoulders and some kind of twist in it.

She had painted her lips bright red to match the dress. That was as vampy as Lana got. I would have loved it if she would have worn sexier clothing: she had the assets for it.

But at the same time, I liked that she didn't. Even that night's outfit, with her lips blaring like a neon sign that said "sex," I was feeling the male energy around me buzzing. Eyes were following her with interest.

She put me in front of her after we got into the club. "Lead the way, I don't know who we're looking for," she said, her hands resting on my hips. She followed me like we were in a Conga line.

When I spotted Nick and his girlfriend, I had a moment of fear. What was I doing, bringing my wife into contact with Nick? He was taller than me, he loved beautiful women, he was alpha and dark-haired and probably had a huge dick.

Lana bumped into me because I had stopped dead in my tracks. She giggled from behind and started up a brief conversation with another Spanish speaker.

Nick's girlfriend was a knock-out. Not to my taste (no one but Lana was to my taste), but to almost any other man she was beyond smoking. Platinum blond hair, a pretty face carefully sculpted by sexy, smokey eye makeup, really nice tits - though obviously fake - spilling from the kind of dress I wished Lana would wear.

She was leaning against Nick as if someone had given her an audition for the role of eye-candy in a mafia movie.

I felt a little better. Nick's type was obviously... this.

Lana was my wife, and she hated men like Nick.

Sure, even though there was potential there - or anywhere - for Nick to get interested in Lana, there was no chance *he* would appeal to *her*.

I even had this thought, which I remember distinctly: I wished that Lana had worn a sexier dress, so that she was presented at her best. Lana was much more beautiful than this cheap blond slut, *and* I had locked her down. It would have been big, big points for me, on that ever-revolving and disintegrating man-scale of status.

Nick waved me over. Lana clattered along behind me, fingers looped beneath my pants. The dance floor was hopping, the place was crowded. Nick had saved us some seats.

"These margaritas are *mean*," Nick yelled, leaning away from his outstretched stance, arms draped over the back of the small half-moon booth. The girlfriend blinked warmly at me, and she looked like she did this for every man. She was a player, her smile said, and she hedged all bets.

I was mildly flattered in spite of myself.

Nick was edging a margarita to his left, looking around for a server. "This is Brandy," he said, waving at the girlfriend.

I shifted to the right and smiled at Brandy, who didn't offer me much except a vacuous smile. "This is Brandy, Nick's girlfriend," I yelled over my shoulder to Lana, who was coming out from behind me, impeded by the many people bumping past us.

Pretty much ignoring Nick, Lana went to Brandy first.

Lana is always kind, even when someone is a caricature of things she professes to despise. She leaned over, tucking a tendril behind her ear, to introduce herself to the woman. "I'm Lana," I heard her yell. She looked around as she continued yelling. "This place is great. Who knew that..."

She continued to talk, but by then my worst nightmare was taking place to Brandy's right and her words melted into the loud, colorful ether.

Nick was getting a look.

His eyes had narrowed, fixated on Lana. Something glimmered in them and turned feral.

I'd seen this look before, or at least I thought I had. It was the look Nick got when he became predatory. He gave it to walls if he was on the phone being a huckster. I had believed - foolishly - it was a by--product of his finance skills, confined to the office.

For the next ten seconds, I entertained a nightmarish fantasy: Lana would look over at Nick, lock eyes with his alpha stare, and think about him at night when we were making love. She would never *do* anything about it - Lana simply wasn't like that. But the attraction would be in there, in her mind, fermenting. Seeping into her thoughts.

Lana did, eventually, look over at Nick.

Their eyes met.

Nick's eyes were steely, dominating and assured. Any man could see that behind them, he was stripping the clothes off my wife and he liked what he saw.

Poor Lana, I actually thought. If she knew the kind of perverted, orifice-imbued thoughts men had about her, she'd turn the color of a beet and never

leave the house again.

Lana was not exactly a creative whore in bed: she was the kind of girl you make love to, and don't dare to sully your chances with by voicing, or tenderly nudging into position for, some dirty idea. She was too cute, too perky, too sweet and pure for any of that.

Neither one of them said anything, though.

Even Brandy picked up on whatever was literally sizzling between them as they both stared at each other. Lana with her mouth slightly open, her eyes beginning to crinkle at the sides, like she was about to squint.

Nick was doing nothing. Nothing at all. But Nick is the kind of man who is very much doing something, always, behind his expressionless face.

Flick, flick, flick: my mind ran filthy images off at a breakneck pace. They overlapped and flew before my eyes. My gut twisted and my heart rate spiked.

Sweaty palms. The whole nine yards.

But this fantasy-nightmare in my imagination was actually the lobby to the real fantasy-nightmare I was about to enter.

Chapter Two

Lana paled first. For a moment I thought she was going to pass out. She spoke before Nick.

"Dom?"

Disbelief dripped from her voice.

In some dusty recess in a backwater of my mind, forgotten scenes between me and Nick slid out from a pile of memories heaped together and destined for the wastelands:

In Nick's office, midday, back when I started:

"Lana, huh? That's a sexy-as-fuck name. I had a Lana once, and let me tell you, that chick was uncontrollable in the sack."

When I had said, "Are you kidding? Lana's always asking me to go," in response to his question about salsa dancing:

Nick's eyes had narrowed, a thought had flashed through his mind, and he had smiled strangely. "Lanas. All the same everywhere, man."

(Now seems as good of a time as any to point out, for the ignorant, which would have included me until I married her: "Lana" is not a Spanish first name, however it may sound so. It is Russian. It was a compromise between her father and her mother: a hispanicization of her grandmother's name, Svetlana).

Upshot: Lanas all over the world do not hit the salsa dance floor en masse.

Nick's conclusion was, therefore, not a conclusion that made any sense. But much of what Nick says is bullshit that his penetrating alpha-stare beats

into acquiescence. So I had ignored the comment almost before he made it. It hadn't raised my eyebrows a millimeter.

Back in the club.

Nick was standing now. His hand was moving toward Lana, who was looking more and more like she was going to need a paramedic. Her skin had turned the color of almond milk, revealing the shade of blush she had used sparingly on her cheeks. Her mouth continued to fall open, micrometer by micrometer - and Lana was big on not being a slack-jawed mouth-breather.

"Chad," Nick admonished me, without taking his eyes off my wife. "You did not tell me you were married to *Lana Cuervo*."

Spare me a moment to describe how the words "Lana Cuervo" left his lips. Like he was pronouncing the name of a hallowed porn star. Like a cocktail of sexual reverence, served and beloved, at decent bars all over the world. Like Lana was famous - for something sexual and slutty - and everyone should know her name.

Lana looked at me. Nick made a smooth move to hide that he had been reaching out to Lana, and picked up a drink instead. He inspected the glass, shrugged, and downed it. "Wow. Blast from the past." He grinned.

Lana had changed her face to a countenance so severe it could have beheaded a lesser man, and then glared at Nick. He grinned in response.

"Well. This is awkward," he said.

Then he put his hands in his pockets, the way you would do to show that they're empty, and looked at me expectantly.

Brandy pointed from one to the other, using a sloshing margarita glass instead of her finger. "Wait. You two know each other?"

"It's in the past," Lana said coolly, turning her icy gaze to Brandy momentarily.

She smiled, lips closed in a line of barely contained rage, rotating toward me. "Your *boss* is Dominic Kane?"

I sputtered to life. Obviously I was supposed to say something here. My boss, after all, *was* Dominic Kane, and the way Lana was saying this made it sound like Dominic Kane was a porn star or a drink or a famous person, and I should have told *her* about him *using his full name*.

"I mean, I... yes, but what did... I never thought to..."

My dad, rest his soul, used to say there are two kinds of smarts in this world, and only two.

Book smarts, and shutting up smarts. I am greatly endowed with one but need coaching on the second.

I closed my mouth.

Nick sat down, shaking his head. "Well holy shit. Lana Cuervo. Have a seat, guys." His eyes took a walk up and down Lana's lithe body, draped in her unrevealing dress. "You look different."

Lana fell into the booth next to Brandy. She looked stunned, but managed a perfunctory smile for Nick's girlfriend.

Brandy was having a strange reaction to all of this.

She sat up straighter, her eyes lit with... *interest*.

"Lana and I," Nick shouted, because the music got louder at that moment, "dated, what...?"

Lana regained her composure and turned to Brandy, putting a hand on her arm and shaking her own head. Her new smile did not seem terse. "It was... a decade ago," she told Brandy. Then she looked up at me. "I'm really just so... shocked. What are the *chances*?"

"Yeah, it was a long time ago," Nick conceded, patting the seat next to him. This was obviously meant as command for me to sit down, so I did, falling into the seat much the same way Lana had. In a coma of the mind.

"I see I barely got any mention," Nick said, looking *me* up and down.

Lana's eyes narrowed and her jaw shifted subtly beneath a smile that seemed incredibly forced. "I *mentioned* you."

She raised her eyebrows.

Nick leaned back, his mouth open. He seemed amused. "Ah," he said.

And then he raised his own eyebrows, before looking from Lana to me, and back again.

Brandy's eyes - and mine - were flicking back and forth between the two of them. It was obvious to me that a subtext had been exchanged, and whatever it was or meant, Nick had received the message.

Lana tipped her head and bored a hole through Nick's skull.

Nick closed his eyes, shook himself, and smiled back at her.

There was a silence at the table. The music blared, cheerful and Latin and in another universe. I wondered what my face was doing, and then I wondered what my face should be doing.

Nick shot a hand into the air and snapped. "We are going to need more booze."

A waitress came to his beck and call and took the drink order from Nick. Lana continued to glare at him over the table. I stood like an idiot, because I didn't know what else to do.

Silence descended upon us again.

Lana set her purse down and turned to Brandy. "Do you know how to salsa?" she screamed.

"Not really," Brandy screamed back.

Lana seized her hand and pulled her out of the booth. "I'll teach you!"

Lana possesses an ability to immediately befriend women of any type, under any circumstances.

If I knew what she did, or how she did it, I'd share the information. It is a superpower.

So Brandy went with her, and I immediately moved to Lana's seat to avoid being crammed up next to Nick - who hadn't budged an inch to accommodate me.

He was chuckling. "Well," he said. "That was... awkward." He spit the adjective out. Nick wasn't one for using the same word twice on the same day.

He slid a margarita across the table with his fingertips on the base. It was seemingly fresh, but the amber color seemed to have been reduced by a sip, and the rim of sugared salt was broken by a lip-sized gap.

"Drink up, buddy. No hard feelings, okay? That was..." his hand fluttered in the direction of the dance floor, which was teeming with dancers and had absorbed Lana and Brandy into its depths, rendering them invisible. "... a million years ago."

He smiled, lips closed. His eyes were on me, reading me - but for what, I couldn't have said. It was almost as if Nick expected me to know something that he knew: maybe he had a huge dick and wanted to see if Lana had reported that, or maybe it was something else.

I looked at the pre-tasted drink.

Surely, I thought, Nick was not trying to make some kind of literary point with this sloppy-seconds drink. It wasn't his style.

His fingertips were still on the base. He followed my eyes, and smiled harder. He inched it closer to me. "Lana, though. Man, how did I *miss* this, dog?" He grinned at me, taking back his hand to thump on the table a little, like he was playing drums.

He shook his head. "I underestimated you, Crobs."

I was paying Nick almost no attention, holding my face together only for appearances' sake.

First and foremost in my mind was this: I had extracted information from Lana about every one of her previous boyfriends. Obviously. Like any man.

In high school she had "dated" a jock, some football quarterback with a simple mind named Henry. Henry had sounded like a description of my buddy Jake: a light-haired, light-hearted guy of medium intelligence and early-peaking ambition.

Lana: "He was too dumb."

This was also something Lana had used to explain to me that she never would have given Jake her number back when we met, which was a question I had definitely asked her. Long was the list of women who met me and Jake at the same time, and Lana was the only one who'd chosen me over Jake.

But then the other boyfriends. In college: a JJ, a Drew, a few meaningless hook-ups (defined by me as guys she kissed or made outwith, but didn't sleep with). Then a boyfriend in Mexico whose name was, inexplicably, Drumi. A handful of short-term relationships that had soured because, in Lana's telling of the whole thing, they had all been "too uncommitted" or "too dumb" or "too possessive."

I tried not to be any of these things. Nick was not any of these things.

"Dom"- I was remembering now - was an uneventful name amid this list. This much, I knew to be true. But the rest of the information about "Dom," was a little fuzzy, because Lana had not offered up the seamy details I really wanted when I had asked her about those relationships.

Sitting there, I realized that I had filed "Dom's" story under "Don," because that's how un-interesting Lana made the relationship sound. She had dated a man named "Don" and didn't have much to say about him.

I was also reasoning - uneasily, with great hope - that Lana had left the two of us at the table together, without supervision. Therefore, whatever it was that had transpired between her and *Dom*, it was in the past, and she wasn't worried about us talking to each other.

That all fit.

It was all fair and not a huge problem.

It was a strange coincidence, nothing more.

"Awkward," as Nick had said twice.

So Nick slept with my wife ten years ago. (At least, I assumed he did. I couldn't see Nick giving a woman who wouldn't put out (immediately) the time of day, and it wasn't like Lana had given me the impression that she was a virgin before me).

It wasn't great.

It wasn't comfortable.

But it wasn't the end of the world.

The waitress appeared with new drinks right after I took a sip of the one Nick had slipped to me, the slightly-used one. I avoided the rim where Nick had presumably left his mouth on it, and sipped. As a sign of goodwill.

So you fucked my wife before, and you're my boss, I broadcast to Nick.

I am a man who is not going to crack up because of that.

I trust my wife.

And *I'm* the one she married.

Self-assured narrative aside, a cold drop of sweat rolled down my spine.

The ladies came back laughing. Brandy was quite drunk. The margaritas flowed. The girls chatted and waved their hands around, besties already, while me and Nick talked shop. We danced, paired up with each other. There was no way to talk over the music, something I was grateful for.

Lana whispered, "Sorry," in my ear, and then said something I didn't hear at all. I assumed it was: "I'll explain later."

I was getting hammered. Lana told me, after my first - they were very "mean," as Nick had said - we'd have to Uber it home, so I really took a deep-dive into the margaritas. At some point Lana said she was tired, and I tried to stop her from sitting down at the table by insisting that I was having a ton of fun dancing.

I was not.

I never am.

Brandy offered to dance with me instead.

Lana waved us away, sliding into the booth.

She was sitting on the opposite side from Nick, who also claimed to need a break.

He did not. He never does.

To prove what a manly man I was - totally unaffected by this news - I danced with Brandy. She had learned nothing from Lana, it seemed. I stole glances at the table when I could, between instructions for the hopeless dancer. Brandy's hands moved everywhere, and she was a natural flirt. I barely paid her any notice, I was so obsessed with my wife.

I saw Lana on her phone once, and Nick hanging his arms over the back of the booth into the next booth, chatting with another woman.

I looked again, minutes later, and Lana and Nick were talking.

When I looked again, Lana was leaning over the table, one finger jabbing at the top of it to emphasize what she was saying. Nick had both arms over the back of the booth and an amused, almost competitive expression on his face.

We spun and spun, Brandy laughing the whole time, her enormous breasts swirling around without moving from their silicone fortress.

Lana and Nick were sitting sullenly in a face-off the next time I saw them. Glaring at each other over the table.

"I need a break!" I told Brandy, and then headed to the booth without waiting for her reaction.

Lana stood up and seized my arm, yawning. "Hey, babe. I'm feeling a little cold coming on. I ordered an Uber. If you want to stay -"

"Nope. No. I mean, yeah, I'm tired, too." Thank *God*. I turned to Nick. He had that same amused expression on his face. The man was very good at looking like nothing affected him, one way or the other.

"Lana's feeling -"

"Yeah man, she's getting a cold," he said, dismissively. He acted like he had known this would be the outcome of the evening.

Brandy pouted and whined. Lana offered to come with her some other time. We exchanged boilerplate goodbyes. Lana kissed Nick on the cheek, but didn't look thrilled about it.

Nick did. He winked at me.

I tried to pick up the bill on the way out, as a way to salvage my dignity somewhat.

But Nick had an open tab and his corporate card back there, and the Uber was waiting, so I left before the waitress could get back with assurances that she could cancel his payment.

Finance is the kind of world where you either get the whole tab or nothing.

"Are you actually feeling sick?" I asked Lana in the Uber.

She looked at me, adjusting her hemline. She rolled her eyes. "No."

Silence.

"So this was Dom."

Lana put a hand to her forehead and looked out her own window. "How is it you never, ever said his name to me?"

"I did. He's Nick. He goes by -"

"I *know* that," she snapped. "I know he goes by Nick. I just... Kane. If you had said 'Nick Kane' then I would have known. Right away."

Lana was so snappy she put me on the defensive. "I don't know any of *your* coworkers' last names," I retorted.

I was pleased with myself. This was irrelevant, but it was true.

Lana dropped her hand and looked over at me, pitifully. "Oh, honey. I'm... gosh. I'm sorry," she said. She tisked a little, a very sudden and disorienting Latina tick that appeared sometimes in her speech.

"I just... I never would have... I mean, it was just kind of awkward..." She looked at me as if she had a suddenly completely different train of thought. "Soooo. What did you guys *talk* about?"

Aware that I should take her offer to lighten the mood, and make a joke out of it, I instead forged ahead. "Remind me when it was that you dated him?"

Lana looked nervous.

She looked nervous *suddenly*, in response to this specific question.

She inhaled, and sighed.

"It was like..." she looked up at the ceiling. "Honey, honestly, I don't even know. Maybe 2012? 2014?"

"So...a long time? Or short?"

"A long time ago, that's why I -"

"How long did you *date him*," I clarified. I was impatient.

She shrugged. "Oh... definitely less than a year."

Lana is a generally truthful person (no one is a fully truthful person). I got the definite sense, however, that there was a lie somewhere in this answer. She looked at her hands.

She couldn't be specific about how long she'd dated a man?

Lana is nothing if not specific.

"Why'd you break up with him?"

Lana did not like this question. Her face went rigid. She pressed her lips together. She focused on her dress, like she needed to prep herself for a fashion shoot and needed it to fall perfectly on the Uber seats.

"Oh, Chad..." she intoned. Like this was all *my* fault. She looked over at me. "Why? What did he say?"

I was taken aback by this answer. So taken aback that I physically mimed being taken aback. "Nothing. But now I want to know."

Lana looked relieved. "Look," she said, turning toward me. "It was a really long time ago. Okay? I wasn't the right kind of...*person* to be dating a guy like Dom."

"-inic," she added quickly. "Nick."

This had the ring of truth about it. Nick was a fucking psycho, if you assessed him on the merits of being a man a woman like Lana would be dating.

Lana was Bambi. Nick was a wolf.

But I'm a man. And I was having man thoughts. I was opening my mouth at that very moment to ask Lana the question I really wanted the answer- and the most expansive, detailed answer I could get - to.

"Did you -"

"Of course I *slept* with him, Chad." Lana delivered this in a very annoyed tone. She fidgeted with her hem and looked out her own window again.

I am a man. I am a man and like any other man I wanted to know a lot more than that.

How. Why. How many times. What the ratio of orgasms was, if his dick was bigger than mine, did she let him do things to her that I didn't, was he as superior physically as he appeared, did she still think of him, did she wrap her legs around him and look in his eyes.

But I am not a stupid man.

I have honed my keep-your-mouth-shut smarts.

I sighed.

"Look," I said, to fill the awkward silence that ensued. I slid my hand over to hers and clutched it. I brought it to my mouth and kissed it. The Uber driver's eyes darted away when I met them in the rear-view mirror. He

hadn't said a word. He was Asian but radiated a third-generation Asianness about him. I suspected he was listening to this whole thing.

My chest got tight. Humiliation washed over me.

"It was just a surprise, is all," I said.

"You got that right," Lana muttered.

"So there's no... you know. Secret feeling that he's the one who got away or - ?"

Lana turned sharply to me and cut my dick off with her glare. "Don't be *ridiculous*. I *told you*." She huffed, and withdrew her hand to pat at her hair.

"I broke up with *him*."

"Why?"

I smiled and tried to make this question sound neutral.

Lana wasn't buying it. She rolled her eyes.

"Just...you know. Because. Because he's... him."

"What does that mean, Lana?"

She was very annoyed by this. "What do you mean, what does that mean? He's in hedge funds -"

"I'm in hedge funds -"

"- he dates women like, like, like like like... *Brandy*. He drives like, I don't know. Cybertrucks. He probably has a yacht. He's not my *type*." Lana shook her hands.

But you slept with him.

I didn't say that out loud. But Lana turned her head and studied my face, down to the exact pressure I was exerting on my lips as I pressed them together.

I didn't have to say it out loud.

Lana rolled her eyes and looked out her own window again.

"Honestly, Chad."

Chapter Three

I don't have a good explanation for myself, or for Lana, or for our relationship, but that was temporarily the end of it.

We didn't talk about Nick again for a while.

I had questions about Nick that I wanted answered. I thought about Nick, and Lana, and Nick and Lana together, all the fucking time. I scrutinized every sexual overture from my wife, every encounter, every time we had sex, for some evidence that Lana was thinking about Nick instead of me.

It had a curious effect. Here I was, feeling the occasional effects of age. You know, where you sometimes would rather go to bed, or jerk off in the shower, than actually fuck. It becomes a psychological game of a whole different kind: instead of trying not to nut off three seconds into sex, you have to put some effort in to get the job *done* once in a while.

This all goes on behind the scenes for me. It's not that Lana isn't spectacularly beautiful, it's just that... well, she likes the same dull, safe, PG-13 stuff. If her attitude could be made into a billboard, it would blare "Don't suggest anything kinky" in neon lights.

But thinking about Nick fucking Lana? For whatever reason that sent me right back to my late teens. My dick was hard, I was ready to hammer a load into her almost as soon as I got going. I had to focus my mind on other things: hockey, car insurance, when the garbage was supposed to go out.

It wasn't that Lana was noticeably different: she kissed like she always kissed and curled, cat-like, into my chest, letting her sexy moans purr over my skin. She wrapped her legs around me and squirmed all the same,

missionary ways she always did. When she got close to coming, she lifted her eyes and let her mouth fall open ever-so-slightly: a moment of weakness and abandon for Lana, who really did have a thing about slack jaws.

I was the one confabulating: in the dark depths of her eyes I chose to see distraction, wandering thoughts. In the movement of her body I deemed every detail "uncanny." I read volumes of fiction into Lana's every move, the fact that her mouth was wetter than usual and saliva clung between her teeth, her eyelashes fluttered more than normal... it was all because Lana was thinking of another lover.

And not just any lover.

Fucking *Nick*.

When the very first spasms of her pussy indicated that she was going to come - she would grind against me now, dig her fingers into the flesh of my shoulder, open her eyes and gasp - I let loose of the building orgasm I had tried to bat down with... thoughts of taxes. It was unusually athletic as I fucked her hard for those final strokes. Lana gripped my shoulders and turned her cheek to my chest, panting. Her pussy clamped down tight on me.

When I rolled off her and lay on my back, I was still panting with the exertion. Lana giggled.

"Wow," she said.

It should be noted that it wasn't like this *never* happened. Sometimes either one of us would get into a mood. Sometimes it aligned that it was both of us and the sex was just a lot better than usual.

It was the first time I questioned it so deeply. I was giving a dental examination to the gift horse.

"What got into *you*?" she asked me.

This was a rhetorical question. It always was. It wasn't the first time I'd been asked, although it was the first time in a long time.

It hit me differently, though. Even if Lana hadn't meant it that way at all, it sent a wave of humiliating implications over me. It stung like that because of all the truths that were lurking beneath the surface:

If something "got into me," that meant that the normal, from Lana's perspective, was a half-mast, sad-suck dick.

And something, furthermore, *had* gotten into me. Not that she could know. Not that I ever wanted her to.

What would I say?

Thinking about you with my boss Nick got into me, sweetheart. It got into me and made my dick hard because I know, in my gut, that you didn't fuck Nick like you fuck me. That Nick didn't fuck you like I fuck you. And because thinking about *that* made me ready to pop.

I looked over at Lana. She was smiling at the ceiling, moving her hand lazily along her own collarbone, lips parted, eyes dark and profound and warmed over with the glow of satisfying sex. She did not have the appearance of a woman who cared about the answer to her question.

So I dropped it.

Like I said:

Keep-your-mouth-shut smarts.

Nick, for his part, is a real asshole - but he's also a good boss. He's not the kind of guy who was ever going to be my good friend: he was the kind of guy who was going to have an entourage if he needed one, and an army of faithful deltas, and it was more likely than not that he'd back you up rather than hang you out to dry - but not guaranteed.

Nick is an alpha-type guy.

He's not an unrelenting jerk, though.

He didn't make any asshole comments about that salsa night in front of anyone, or waltz into work yelling "it was sure nice seeing my ex-girlfriend, buddy" over the desks, on the way into his glass-encased office. He made it pretty clear, actually, that he wasn't going to bring it up.

So I didn't, either.

Two weeks went by like this.

And then, as we were breaking up a small meeting about a big account and how we were going to calm the investor down, Nick came up behind me as we were leaving and pulled one of his best moves.

He shut the door and locked me in with him, turning to me and speaking in a low voice, like anyone but an FBI agent could hear through the three inches of solid wood.

"I didn't want to say this in front of everybody, because, you know..." he was turning toward me, grimacing, sucking air through his teeth. "I don't want all these jackasses at my house. But I'm having a cocktail party

tomorrow night. My place. Powell will be there. Brandy... Brandy's, you know. Hot. But she hates this shit, and the less she talks to investors... I don't need to explain. The better. So do me a solid, okay? Come. Bring Lana."

"Uh... tomorrow?" My head was spinning.

"Look," Nick said. "You're not hung up on that shit, are you?"

"No-"

"Good." He punched me in the shoulder. He grinned. "It was a long time ago. So I can count on you? Bring Lana. Please bring Lana. *Please* tell Lana to talk to Brandy. Brandy really liked her. And, I don't need to explain this: Brandy doesn't need to talk to investors."

He opened the door.

I saw myself out.

By the time I got back to my own desk, he had texted me the address, followed by a military time.

"A cocktail party."

Lana had her arms crossed over her chest and she looked like I had just suggested we move to a nudist colony.

"Listen," I said, sitting on a stool and holding my hands out to her in supplication. She put her hands in mine (thank fuck). I squeezed them. "Nick is a fucking crazy guy. He wants me there, and he wants you there - but he specifically said, like, you know... for Brandy. Brandy really liked you. He knows it was awkward, he said so-"

"Dom said it was awkward. This party."

Lana did not try to make this into a question or temper her disbelief. She was straight-up calling me out on an obvious lie. And it burned, under my skin: she knew Nick well enough to know that he would never say something like that.

I faltered.

It drove me crazy - *crazy*- that she called him "Dom."

"He said *those* words." Lana had an arched eyebrow. This was not a question, either.

Nick *had* said it was awkward, but back in the salsa club. Still.

I nodded solemnly. This made Lana roll her eyes.

I squeezed her hands. "Look, honey. I wouldn't be asking you except that... you know. This is kind of important. And Nick specifically asked for you."

"To babysit his child bride. Yeah, okay."

I stared at Lana. "Are you...? I mean, are you still hung up on something with him, because -"

"Oh my gosh, Chad. Seriously. No. No, I am not hung up on Dominic Kane. But I don't exactly want to stand around talking to his bimbo girlfriend all night."

Bullshit began oozing out of my pores. This is an occupational hazard. If you want to be totally honest, hedge fund management is 98% bullshit. Purely a confidence game. You have to say whatever someone needs to hear to get them to give you their money so you can engage in glorified, legal gambling.

Want a pro-tip? Nobody fucking knows what the stock market will do. No-bo-dy.

Bullshit comes easily to me, because bullshit is the name of the game, even in back-of-the-house accounting, where I technically fall.

It felt weird doing it to Lana, though.

"Look. Okay. Nick is... I know him, okay? He's trying to smooth this whole thing over. I don't think he's any more comfortable with it than you are -"

I interrupt my retelling of my own discourse, which in real life went on uninterrupted. But when I said this, Lana scoffed and shook her head. Subtly, but she did it.

"- and I think that's why he wants to extend, you know, an olive branch. This is a big account. It's not locked down. It's a big chance for me to show Nick my chops. Brandy really did seem to like you. And she's, you know... well, she is a little dim. He doesn't want her talking finance to his guests. So... can you just help me out? Play along?"

Nick extending an olive branch was just about the purest concentration of bullshit I'd ever dispensed. It was couched in there with 'I think...' so that it wasn't technically a lie.

Was Nick trying to smooth this whole thing over?

I doubted it. It wasn't his style.

Lana put her hand to her mouth and *laughed* behind it.

"*What?*" I said defensively.

She shook her head. She snorted, like she does when she thinks something is really funny and the laugh escapes her control. "You really do not know Dominic Kane *at all*, do you?"

She didn't leave any time for me to respond. She plucked her dry cleaning up from the back of a chair where she'd laid it carefully at the beginning of this talk, and swished away with a sexy butt wag and the crinkle of soft plastic. "I'll go. For you. But I don't believe a word of that nonsense."

I let her leave.

I marveled at her directness.

She was in the bedroom a long time. She left her gourmet pizzas in the oven, and the timer blared repeatedly, but she didn't come out. I took them out and left the oven on, set off the smoke alarm, disabled it, and opened a window. And Lana still didn't re-appear.

I headed down the hall. Our room is at the end of it, and the door was open to a clear view into it. Lana was standing over the bed on her side, the dry cleaning still draped over one shoulder. Her phone was in her free hand, and she was typing. Her face was set in a stony glare and her attention was absorbed.

She caught the movement of my body and looked over quickly. She dropped the phone after a few swipes, and swung the dry cleaning in front of her, walking toward the closet and out of view. "Sorry, honey -just... I'll be right there!" she called out.

"You didn't hear the smoke alarm?" I kept approaching, my eyes on the phone. The screen lit up with an incoming message. I stepped more quickly, suspicion with no clear shape forming like a cloud in my vision. Lana walked quickly out of the closet, free of the dry cleaning.

She sighed theatrically. "I'm sorry. I heard it. I just - I got caught up in this... rec center drama..." Her voice trailed off as she picked up the phone and scanned the message.

Then she turned it off, and looked at me brightly.

She seemed manic, talked to me like I was child under her care. "Did you burn them? Okay. Let's go see."

And she flew past me and into the hallway.

I turned, open-mouthed, a grin of disbelief on my face. When I started after her, she was talking again, her chin to her chest, the phone clearly in her hands as she typed.

Or deleted messages.

Or covered her tracks.

How was I supposed to know? But she was talking to me like I was child, so something was up.

"This...Shelby is just... I'd tell you about it, but it's like.... kinder....garden... uh..." she murmured.

Who among us, after all, has not said dumb shit like this while trying to cover up a less-than-kosher text exchange?

"Phew!" she declared, entering the kitchen. "They're fine."

The pizzas were burnt at the edges. Lana ignored this, contrary to her health-conscious, carcinogen-slaying nature. She babbled about the smoke detectors.

I let it go. She set her phone on the counter, unlocked, and declared that she was just going to go to the bathroom real quick.

"...okay? Get the wine poured. Those need to sit for a bit anyway."

All this talking was all theater.

Of that much, I was sure.

I looked at the phone. Lana closed the bathroom door really loudly. I spun it toward me and looked at her texting app.

I figured this was what she wanted me to do. *And* what she wanted me to find:

Nothing.

The most recent messages were from a "Nora Hildebrant." The preview text said: "Yes! That's perfect. Let's meet at..."

Then messages from me. I had last texted at noon. The time on Nora's message was 5:45. Almost half an hour ago.

I spun the phone around and turned off the screen so it would lock. I poured the wine, thinking about who the fuck "Nora" and "Shelby" were - two names I never heard.

I had to admit to myself, though, that Lana's work-related dramas were confusing and boring. I didn't listen very well. There could very well be a "Nora" or a "Shelby" or both, but they seemed made-up.

Still, it hung in the air, the bad vibes this was giving me.

I felt like my wife was lying to me - outright. Not innocently, not inconsequentially.

But what about?

What was I secretly accusing her of? Texting Nick?

The dark fantasy seemed to have its genesis in my balls. It stretched and grew, spreading out to my abdomen and gnawing inside my chest. She was back there sending messages to Nick, that's why the distraction...

The door unlocked loudly. Lana - it seemed to me - thumped down the hall. "Okay! I'm ready to eat!" she called.

Things did not add up. The loud banging of the door, the leaving the phone on the counter, the texting through a smoke alarm, the proximity of all this weird behavior to me inviting her to Nick's party.

But also not adding up were the threads of my fantasy/nightmare.

Texting Nick *why*? How? Where would she have even gotten the phone number?

Nick had asked *me* to bring *her*, and if she had anything to do with that, why would it send her into a panic? Why would she scoff? Why would she then agree to do it, if it was some devious plan she didn't want to be a part of? Why would she resist it, if she did? Why would she risk texting distractedly right after accepting, if something was afoot?

None of it made any sense in either interpretation.

She was in the kitchen now, pushing back her hair to examine the pizzas. She picked up a wine glass and sipped it. She didn't even look at her phone.

She started to cut them apart - half of each for me, sliced up.

Lana's halves were left unsliced. She eats pizza with a fork and knife and she has a strange thing about wedges. (Basically, she doesn't like them. She also won't eat wedged fruit).

"So what are we supposed to wear to this thing?" she asked me, cutting up her own pizza. She put a piece in her mouth and chewed.

So the cocktail party was on Lana's mind, at the forefront. Just like it was in my mind.

"No idea," I said.

Lana finished chewing, nodding like she expected that answer. "Well. Can you find out? Because if I have to get something, I have to rearrange some stuff."

"Sure," I said.

"Oh, not now," she said, putting her hand on mine, as I reached for my phone. "Let's eat first."

So we did.

Chapter Four

Something sexy.

Lana had rolled her eyes at this (text from Nick) and donned a black cocktail dress that she claimed to have owned since her first year of university. It was typically Lana: boring, to her knees, unable to hide her stunning figure, and not very remarkable. She pulled her hair into a loose "fancy bun" and stuck some red-jeweled pins into it. Her earrings were understated gold orbs, and she vaguely looked like Audrey Hepburn, with no pearls.

I told her so, and she said pearls would clash with the hair pins.

She did not seem to spend a huge amount of time on her makeup, but it was decidedly vampier than usual. At least to my mind. She had a coat of black mascara on her lashes, which required none. Dark shadow made her eyes pop, sexy and alluring, from under the long, fluttering strands. Her mouth was a neutral pink, but decidedly painted, and the shade was slutty in some indefinable way.

She was dressed, however, like she was going to my boss's cocktail party to talk about business.

My suspicions began to seem ludicrous.

There were a ton of people there, making my suspicions seem even sillier. Nick's house was in a neighborhood bordering on a private golf club, and his expansive lawn backed up to the green, but a stone fence separated it. He had a black slate pool and a waterfall in his front yard. The ceilings were high, the architecture tacky.

My family was in construction, so I saw immediately that Nick had commissioned the most expensive building materials available. This was the kind of house whose design, at every turn, had been chosen for the purposes of displaying Nick's wealth and no other reason -certainly not taste. There was a five-car garage. I half-expected to see stables.

Lana got out of the car and surveyed the scene.

"Nice place," I said.

Lana looked at me. She linked her arm in mine. "Gaudy," she stated.

I couldn't tell how true this was, not in my state of mind. But it seemed to be her honest opinion.

"So was this... where did Nick live, when you dated him?"

Lana gave me some side-eye. "In an even bigger house," she told me.

It took me a while to get that it was a joke.

I followed Lana in, because she walked right up like she owned the place. Not Lana's style. It itched under my skin.

If anything, Lana would have done well as a politician's wife. She was buttoned-up just the right amount, a minority in just the right amount, and she had an amazing, welcoming smile. She never made lewd remarks or gestures, and she never did anything that could be considered flirting. She strolled right in and started introducing *me* to people I'd forgotten.

I left her with a few folks in the living room, where a string quartet was, very improbably, playing.

"Crobs, great, you're here," Nick said, appearing next to me and walking at a fast pace. I fell into line with him, because Nick's default mode was fast walking. He pushed a door open to what seemed to be an exact copy of the kitchen we had just walked through, and looked behind him. "Where is Lana?" He threw open one of two stainless steel fridges, waving at it and citing some statistics about how much it cooled and how much it cost, removing a bottle of water and chugging it. "I need you to get Brandy off my back."

I looked around. We were obviously in some kind of service kitchen, because the catering staff were the only people in there.

"Uh...okay, well, Lana is out there and -"

"Great. Listen. Go find her, put them together, and get her away from me."

If Nick were any other guy - different job (not my boss), different demeanor (not alpha Nick), different man (not my wife's ex-lover) - I would

have said something else. I'm no doormat.

"Sure," I told him, hands in my pockets.

He wiped his mouth, his eyes shifting from side to side.

Most people think Nick does a lot of blow, and in our business, it'd be unsurprising. He seems like a guy who's had ten lines by 8am. My personal take is that Nick's just like that. Like a man on coke. Naturally.

"Great. I got Helena Lockheed on the hook out there."

"Oh yeah?" I asked neutrally, and Nick clapped me on the back, finishing off his water.

"Yeah buddy." And off he went.

I found Brandy almost immediately after that. This is because Nick pointed at her head, from behind her, and pointed me out to her.

Brandy was in an outfit that looked ten years too young for even her. Her hair was twisted up in two buns like she was headed for a rave, and a sheer black dress barely covered what looked like a black boy-short and sports-bra combo.

This lent incredible credibility to Nick's story - of wanting Lana to be here to keep Brandy, and her dirty high-school girl shtick, away from investors.

Brandy had a straw in her bright pink drink and she lifted the straw, with a finger over the top, to her tongue to deposit the contents by releasing the top finger. Her tongue was pink, and the child-like gesture unsubtle. Just watching it made me feel like a pedophile.

"Hi, Chad," she purred, grinning.

Behind her, Nick was smiling at me and mouthing, "Take her somewhere else."

I glanced around the room, looking for Lana.

"Lana's looking for you," I told Brandy.

She dribbled some pink slush onto her pink tongue, allowing me to note that she had a tongue ring. She smiled, and then said, in an incongruously sexy voice: "Is she?"

She fluttered her eyelashes.

"Uh...yes," I told her, as earnestly as I could. Brandy shifted in her sexy dress, like she had started dancing to some unheard music.

"Let's go find her, then," Brandy said, grasping my left arm.

I followed Brandy, at first hopeful that she would take me in the direction of Lana. I began to despair when she wanted to show me the upstairs.

"Uh..."I balked, at the foot of the enormous staircase.

"She's probably on the tour," Brandy told me. She was skipping up the steps, cheerful and carefree.

I could have told, but did not tell, Brandy that Lana didn't go on "tours" of houses, because she thought it was tacky. I followed her anyway.

To be fair, a few people did seem to be up there as tourists, though they didn't seem guided by anyone.

Brandy swished into the master bedroom. "I just want to grab something real quick," she called back. I hesitated. She turned and smiled impishly at me. "I'm not going to *bite* you. Just follow, so I can keep talking to you."

She stopped talking, though. I put myself respectfully by the door, one eye out for Nick or Lana.

Brandy kicked off her shoes and opened a drawer, then threw herself on the bed with a small box that contained all kinds of drug paraphernalia.

"You want a bump of something?" she asked me, her fingers working quickly through the box. "I have -"

"I'm good."

Brandy looked at me for a moment, amused, and kicked her feet carelessly in the air. Then she shrugged, rolled around, a joint that didn't seem entirely made of pot between her lips, and put the box back onto the dresser she had taken it out of. She walked into the adjacent bathroom.

"So what does Lana do, again, for a living?" she was saying. I reluctantly followed her, because she obviously expected me to. I also didn't want to be yelling in here.

The bathroom was huge, and Brandy was perched next to a window on a tiled bench on the opposite side of a huge standing bath tub. She blew smoke out the window. "Don't tell Nick. He hates when I smoke in here."

I scratched my head. "Yeah, well..."

"So Lana. She told me, but I forget."

"She's in, uh, sort of a social work thing."

Brandy blew the smoke out with a serious face, right at me. "Seriously?" She laughed. "Wow." She tapped the ash into the bathtub and ignored it. She was looking at me expectantly.

I looked back at her.

"I take it you're the shy one," she said, after a while.

"I, uh... guess so..."

Brandy smiled. "So you just let her pick her own guys?" She sighed and blew some smoke out the window after making this strange comment, and looked rueful. But only momentarily. She turned back to me after putting it out in a tall Montserra pot. She chewed her lower lip in momentary thought.

Very momentary.

"Hey," she said. "If you close the door we can sneak in a quickie."

She began to move as if I'd accepted this proposition. She uncrossed her legs, she stepped into and then out of the tub, she lifted her see-through skirt to show me a glimpse of her shorts. Her eyes went to the door.

"Oh. Oh. Gosh... Brandy. Hey, um... you're my boss's girlfriend -"

"I *know*," she said, crazily, still coming at me. Her hands were behind her back now, unzipping the dress. I looked out of the bathroom and into the master bedroom.

"Nick likes it when I sneak something in," she whispering to me. She caught the door and started to close it, grinning. Her dress was falling from her shoulders. "It's a game we play." She slipped one hand into her boy shorts and began to move her fingers beneath the garment.

There was no way for me not to at least *look* at that. She brought one finger up, as she closed the door, and put it between her teeth. "I try to get my finger on his drink, or into his mouth -"

"Uh, Brandy... wow, okay..." I pushed the door open, making Brandy's expression change. It shifted from her sexy elation, to confused, to angry, in almost no time at all.

As for me, I wasn't really even processing the words Brandy had said. Or maybe I was, but it was taking a long time.

"He won't be *mad*," she told me. She grinned. "He *likes* it when I sneak around first."

"Uh...listen... um, Brandy... you are... like, very, very, hot..." I began. "But Nick is my boss, and this is... so I'm just gonna..."

Brandy put a hand on one hip. She looked thoroughly confused, and the way she was doing it somehow made me feel like I was the one who was out of line.

"I really shouldn't have followed you in here," I told her. "I,uh..."

"Is this Nick?" she asked, sliding her dress back up. She rolled her eyes. "He told you to put me and Lana together, didn't he?" She rolled her eyes.

And then, she licked her top teeth. "Don't get me wrong, I'm into it, but..."

Nick's girlfriend, Brandy, a blond bombshell, looked me up and down.

And if she hadn't been saying such bonkers shit, I have to tell you, I might have lost my composure. Maybe not, but I wouldn't mortgage my house on it.

It didn't happen that way, though. Brandy was saying crazy shit, and it was crazy enough to keep me from engaging with her on that level.

"...you know, who is this for, really? Sometimes..." she was getting dangerously close to me again, "I feel like you guys forget who this is all for..."

I grasped her hand, which was wandering down my chest, toward my cock, which was hard and pushing against my jeans. "I, uh... Brandy, you are so hot, but this is..." I shook my head. "I have to find Lana."

"Is that a rule?" Brandy said, cozying up to me. I had my back against the wall. She got a hold of the door and pushed it closed. Then she started sliding down in front of me. "You know everyone likes it when you break the rules just a smidge..."

For one brief moment, I closed my eyes and thought about going with the flow. What man hasn't fantasized about hot women just throwing themselves at him? But thoughts of Lana are never far from the forefront of my mind.

"Whoa!" I said, jumping to the side, covering my crotch. "Okay," I hissed. "Brandy. Okay. Okay, okay, okay, okay... look, just, uh... I don't... I can't..."

Brandy scowled at me, then scoffed, then let out a giggle and covered her mouth. "Hold on... are you -? Are you *for real*?" Then she shrugged. "Well. *Hot*, I guess. Saving it up..." her eyes went to my crotch and she bit her lip.

It was theatrical. I gave her a strange look and held a hand up to her. "Brandy... seriously, you are, uh... really hot, and really... but I'm.... married."

I held up my wedding ring.

Brandy became interested in that. "Do you think that makes it hotter?"

My mouth fell open. "Makes what...?"

She grinned and came at me again.

I fended her off by moving away. "Brandy, really -"

She stopped and looked at me. "Wait," she said. "Are you... not...?" She blinked and moved her head in a microscopic shake, like she wanted to clear a fly from her airspace without anyone noticing.

Her hands flew to her mouth and she stared at me over her clasped hands, her eyes wide in shock. "Oh, my!" she exclaimed. "Wait a minute, you aren't...?"

I looked at her, helpless to finish the sentence.

"Wow, oh, okay. I just assumed that with, you know..." she waved behind her at the door. "Nick and everything. Lana." She squinted at me. "*Really?*"

I had no answer. I did not understand even the gist of what she was saying, not really - and I knew that I should. I knew it was dangerous not to. I was still covering my crotch like I was expecting someone to kick a penalty in my direction.

Brandy's mouth fell open. "Does he -?" She looked behind her. "Does Nick know?"

"Know what?"

She was taken aback.

She blinked.

"Uh...about Lana, like... you know. *Reforming*." She struggled with this word and laughed her way through it. "Or wait. Are you like, into being like, a pure cuck?"

That made much more sense to her. She showed it all over her face.

I opened my mouth, shaking my head, desperate.

I had no idea what to say to that. At all. Brandy wasn't even saying it derisively. I replayed the tape in my head at least twice. She did say "cuck."

Didn't she?

Brandy looked like she was about to say one last seductive, weird thing, but then her mouth snapped shut and her eyes went really wide. "Oh, shit," she said.

I looked at her frantically. "Oh, shit," *now?*

Why now?

Brandy stepped toward me. "I am so sorry. I think maybe I - I think maybe the less I say, the better. I, uh, really misread... the situation." She crinkled up her nose. "So there's no chance?"

"What are you *talking* about?" I demanded.

"Nothing. Noooooooooo thing. Hey Chad, be a Chad, and don't tell, uh, Nick, about this?" She turned the handle on the door, scrunching her nose distastefully. "It sorta kills the vibe. You know?" She stepped into the room.

"So, just checking..." she called from the bedroom. "Lana's off the table, too?"

I walked out of the bathroom, squinting right back.

"Uh-huh," Brandy said, cheerily, as if I'd answered her. She was putting her shoes on. "Okay. Well. This never happened, and I was never here." She strolled by me, putting a hand on my jaw. Her fingers were silky and playful. "If you change your mind, though..."

And away she went.

I found Lana at long last, after doing some glad-handing and charming whoever happened to stop me to talk to them. Her eyes went to me, severe. Whatever she saw as she scanned me, she changed her expression back to one of neutrality.

Nick's party was an evident mixture of business and pleasure, which in Nick's case meant a lot of seemingly coked-up nutjobs into extreme sports, attractive and vacuous women, and dudes talking about their boats.

Normally, I would have spent this time enduring the pressure to get myself a boat by thinking about ways to talk Lana into it. It's extremely difficult to navigate my socioeconomic class without a boat to talk about, but Lana thinks boats are a waste of money. It's even harder to get around this because, as a glorified accountant, I cannot help but agree with her.

Instead of these mental gymnastics, though, I was totally preoccupied looking around for my wife. Snippets of the strange conversation and interaction with Brandy were on repeat in my head. They jumbled together, mixed and matched, and after a while... seemed like they hadn't even really happened.

This was not the first time I'd been too flattering of myself and taken the wrong cues from a woman, after all. But what man leaves an interaction like *that*, thinking the woman wasn't hitting on him?

Brandy had also been - to say the least - somewhat cryptic.

My life goal with Lana was to not fuck up our marriage entirely because of bad communication. I was convinced this is why everyone got divorced, why every man cheated, why women had affairs. So I wasn't pleased with myself as I began creeping around, looking for Lana, as opposed to just waiting until later to ask her what the hell was going on.

This is what I should have done. I should have told Lana all about Brandy's aggression, and then asked her what she thought was going on.

But taken with Lana's weird phone thing from earlier, and her weird reactions to everything to do with Nick, this Brandy thing was just one more cryptic clue. It raised the specter of something I didn't want to confront. I didn't know what it was but I knew i didn't want to face it.

This is why I found myself climbing the steps, three at a time, my thighs burning with the effort, a drink sloshing dangerously in a glass. It's why I was in a small bedroom that appeared to never have been used, but always dusted by meticulous housekeepers. It's why I was cranking open the window as discretely as possible, and leaning on the window well (a deep, oak-encrusted feature that allowed me place an elbow on it). It is why I had locked the door to the unused bedroom, in the hopes of keeping people out.

Why?

Because Lana and Nick, the last I saw them through the kitchen and the living room and a pane of glass, were clustered together beneath that window, having a conversation.

I was out of breath from the way I'd hurried up there, so I could barely hear them at first over my huffing. I made a note to do more cardio, like I always do.

There were other people near them, on the patio, jabbering loudly, so the conversation came in patches that barely made any sense for a bit.

In fact, it seemed mundane at first.

Lana was talking about work: I'd heard this story enough times that I recognized the names, and the timbre of her voice. Something about Saturdays...

Then Nick's voice cut through, abruptly. That was Nick's style: changeable, daring, abrupt, dominating. "So what's with your Chad husband? You're all... look at this thing -"

A huffy giggle. "What thing?"

"Your dress. Your... pony-tail." I thought I heard a snort. "You aren't... *something, something*... Not really, Lana."

"It's all true."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. Yes. Okay? So just... *listen*. Do me a solid, okay? And don't bring it up -"

Nick again: "You haven't told him."

Silence. A snicker.

"Okay, Lani -"

"Don't call me that."

"Okay, Mrs. Robinson. I mean - oh, hey, Rick! Come here for a second...."

Someone else joined them, and they all chatted. It was business and boats. I reached to close the window, giving up on overhearing anything else, when "Rick" left the scene.

"So," Lana said.

"So." Nick. Amused. Full of himself.

"Dom, please. Okay? For me. Just... keep it under wraps."

"You know I would do anything for you, Lani -"

A slap.

Not hard. Playful. But jarring: not Lana's style.

I leaned carefully to try and see where Lana's hand had gone, but they were tucked under the soffit.

Nick was chuckling. "Just tell me one thing, okay?"

Silence. I could guess that Lana was staring at him with an awful look she reserved for when I was being my most ass-tastic.

More chuckling. I saw Nick's hand waving around. "Okay, okay, you're all reformed, he doesn't know a thing, but just please, please, please tell me Lana: what did you tell him about your -"

"*Nothing.*"

Lana hissed this violently.

There was a silence. Cicadas seemed to sense the tension and fill it in.

"Nothing. Okay... nothing." Nick's chuckle rumbled, disbelieving to its core. "I mean -"

"Nothing. Dominic. And that's that."

"It's just that -"

Another hiss.

"Okay. All right. Look, Lana, I'm being serious now. Okay? I'm happy for you. I'm... you do you. I mean that. There's no reason Chad needs to know about any of it."

"Thank you."

"Yeah, okay, maybe. And I'm saying this for you, Lana, not... well maybe a little for myself - Lana, please, don't blow up..."

Lana was trying to leave, but Nick had her arm and pulled her back.

"Listen. I'm serious, though, for a minute. I mean... eventually he's going to-"

"No. He's not. Not if *you* can keep your mouth shut."

"Okay, but... come on, Lana. Tell me... okay look, I promise, I promise, I'll keep my mouth shut, if that's what you want, but you have to tell me one thing."

Big sigh from Lana. She was irritated.

"What did you *tell him* about -"

"*Noth-ing.*"

Silence.

"Nothing, okay?" Lana repeated.

"What, did he just like, not notice -"

"Yes. Okay?"

A complaint. "Oh, Lana, that's..." A snicker from Nick. *That's unbelievable.* Then, with a hint of hopefulness: "Hey, what did you do with it?"

"None of your business."

Nick made a noise. "It kind of *is*, Lana, that was titanium, it had a diamond in it -"

Another sigh from Lana. "Would you believe? There's not a huge market for that kind of thing, used."

A silence. Lana tried to leave. I saw her hair, which picks up mahogany highlights in the sun, and her arm, emerging from under the soffit.

Nick's voice: "You don't have it lying around, then, do you? Somewhere?"

He was drunk. Or high. This was the first time I noticed it. He was way out-of-bounds, very suddenly, in his tone, in his words. More than before.

Lana looked around and turned to him in exasperation. I stepped back slowly, to ensure that I couldn't be glimpsed if she looked up. Her voice was very whispery, but sharp: "Are you *serious?*"

"It was an expensive piece, Lana. And the guy... hey, look. Look, look, look, the guy... that was expensive as fuck. Okay? The guy doesn't make them anymore. And I, for one, loved that thing, it was -"

"*Dominic!*" Lana hissed, walking back to him. "Shut *up.*"

"Okay!" Nick yelled loudly. Then quietly: "Okay. Ssshhhh. But seriously, Lana. If you aren't using it... you know... maybe you could sell it back to me -"

"That is disgusting."

A pause. "Yeah, well," Nick agreed, in his very obnoxious-charming way. "It's not like it can't be sterilized."

"Oh, God."

"Tell you what, Lana?"

There was a long silence.

"You get that back to me, and I'll make sure not to accidentally let anything slip out, to your new man, disrupt your suburban soccer-mom thing you seem to have baking in that oven. Okay? Seems fair."

Another silence. I was craning my neck to look down the sheer face of the house, and it was making my eyeballs hurt. Lana hadn't moved. I couldn't see her face but I could feel the Latina fury building up inside her.

It *hummed*.

"It was expensive," Nick whined, using a voice I'd never heard before.

"That's not why you want it." Lana's voice, too, was like nothing I'd ever heard before.

"Nope. Nope, it's not. But now I want it because I want it. And you *have* to give it to me."

There was a definite sexual undertone to this part of the conversation, or I was a pineapple upside-down cake.

I thought I heard a snicker. I had no idea which one of them it could have come from. "That's bold," Lana said.

Nick laughed. "Yeah, it is a bit. Okay. And you know what, Lana? Just to top it off? I'm going to give it to *Brandy*. That's my plan. *Somebody* should enjoy it."

Silence.

"Fuck you, Dom."

This made my eyes go wide. Lana was never this crass, and she rarely cussed.

Silence. I pictured them staring each other down.

Then Lana's laugh broke the silence.

"Fine. Fine. Okay. Whatever. To make this go away." A pause. "Nothing has changed about you, you know that?" Lana walked out from under the soffit, her head turned over her shoulder, a smile with an incongruous sexiness in it on her lips.

"You know, that's as true about you as it is about me," Nick called out after her, sounding almost... deflated.

Lana snorted, like an angry horse, and stomped off.

"Whatever. I would like it back, though!" Nick called out after her. His petulance turned into his regular, carefree act toward the end.

I gently closed the window, heart pounding, mind on fire.

And then I worked my way out of that room and hid in a bathroom, trying to piece the whole evening together. But I couldn't, not in a way that would enable me to approach my wife about it.

Hey, so Brandy tried to fuck me in the room I followed her into, and she said some shit, and then I was eavesdropping on your conversation with Nick, and...

I stared at the wall.

Good communication. Here I went. Just as soon as I figured out some way to communicate good, without communicating all of my own sins.

A ring? What else had titanium and diamonds in it?

You might think I'm stupid, since you almost undoubtedly know where this story is headed, but I couldn't put it all together. And the main reason for that is because, when it came to Lana, my brain just sidestepped all the filthy thoughts, however promising. The entire field of them. Like they didn't even exist if Lana was anywhere near.

Lana wore skirts to her knees and collars that barely showed off her chest. She seemed like she'd walked straight out of the fifties and felt mildly uncomfortable with all the drugs, sex, and rock and roll around.

But...

She dated Nick.

She slept with Nick.

A little demon on my left shoulder sneered: *and what do you suppose that was like?*

Okay.

Okay. So Nick gave my wife a ring, and she kept it. No biggie. Right?

And she kept it, but she was giving it back. In exchange for Nick not providing any details about their relationship.

The event with Brandy was even more indecipherable.

Both of these things happening next to each other at this party, I reasoned, did not mean they had anything to do with each other.

But no matter why it was that Brandy had the impression that I was going to fuck her, and was surprised that I didn't... and no matter what this titanium and diamond ring was about, one thing I did know to be true:

Nic khad repeatedly promised Lana that he would *not* tell me something.

And Lana had very much wanted him to do that.

Not tell.

I was boxed into an unfortunate situation: I couldn't just ask her straight up, without admitting to eavesdropping on her.

And if there was one thing I knew Lana hated - because she'd stated it explicitly - it was her boyfriends or her husband "keeping tabs obsessively" on her. The following another woman - of Brandy's type, to boot - into another room and being alone with her was something Lana had never specifically said would infuriate her.

But taking a stab at it, I suspected she wouldn't receive that story very well. Or be very charitable in her interpretation of it.

So how was I going to get to the bottom of all this through "good communication?"

And so, gentle reader, went my thinking.

That is why I did all of this spectacularly stupid shit subsequent to this party.

Chapter Five

"Did you have a nice time?"

We were in the Uber home, sitting silently, and this was as good of a question as I could come up with. Lana seemed pissed off and preoccupied. I felt sure it was because of her conversation with Nick, but I also hoped to flesh out if she had keyed in on anything that went on with me and Brandy. I had seen her chatting with Brandy as the party wore on.

She turned to me. "Not really."

"Me, either."

Lana frowned. She reached for my hand. "Listen, honey... I don't want to make any waves, because... how drunk are you?"

"Not very," I lied.

"Maybe I should just wait..."

"No, no, no... listen. Don't wait. Just tell me. Whatever it is. I promise I won't act like an asshole."

Like Nick, I added silently.

Lana sighed and looked out her own window. Her eyes went to the driver, who really did seem to not follow English exceedingly well.

Back to me.

"I know I said, or implied, or... whatever... that this thing with Dom wasn't a big deal. And it isn't. At all. At least not, like... well, you know what I mean..."

I didn't.

"...But it's awkward. And, uh, I don't know. I want to avoid this kind of thing -"

"Honestly, me too."

Lana's eyebrows went to the sky. "Really?" She sounded relieved. Then she frowned. "Why?"

"Uh...well, it's... awkward... I mean, why do you?"

"What?"

I was drunk, so this was confusing to me. In my drunkenness, I interpreted this as hostility. Or something. I went on offense.

"Why do you want to avoid Nick? Is there something you need to tell me?"

Lana wilted for a moment, and I felt bad. Then I felt worse. After all, Lana had just been trying to broach the subject.

Also, I technically had something to tell *her*, if we were being honest.

Which again, I wasn't really doing.

But a man's ego knows no bounds. Especially after countless (uncounted) units of alcohol.

"I do, actually. And you're not going to like it."

I braced myself. I hadn't really expected her to cough this up, even knowing her as well as I do. Not this soon. Not in the car.

She was plowing ahead. "I have something of Nick's."

"What is it?"

I asked this question too quickly. I asked it without masking my interest, without feigning surprise. Lana almost definitely picked upon this. She narrowed her eyes. She also looked scared.

She sputtered a little, but then dove in. "It's just a... like a... some jewelry. I don't know why I kept it. I don't, I just... I need to give it back to him, is all. And then, I kind of want to, you know... avoid him. If that's okay with you."

"How did this conversation come up?"

"*What?*" Lana glared at me. "That's what your question is?"

This response mixed poorly with my state of mind, and the booze. I leaned back against the door and looked at her. "Yeah. Yes. That's my question. You were... what? In the kitchen? Opening a bottle of wine, and Nick came by and said, 'Oh, hey, Lana, you have this ring I gave you. I want it back.'? Or what? How did it go?"

Lana, self-declared queen of the anti-mouth-gaping action committee, gaped at me, open-mouthed. "I wasn't... what? It's not even a...! I don't know, Chad. It just came up. In conversation."

"Nick brought up, or you did?"

Lana was on the back foot, which only made me more suspicious. A full half of my brain was trying hard to remember which of them *had* actually brought it up. I had to remind myself that it was better that I couldn't remember. I had been eavesdropping, after all.

"You're drunk," Lana sighed. "We'll talk about it later."

"I'm not so drunk I can't understand the answer to a simple question. You talked about an old ring with Nick, and I just want to know, you know, as your current husband, who brought it up? Nick? Or you?"

Lana looked shocked. She shook her head as she answered, in that way that denotes disappointment. "I don't remember."

I scoffed at this. I wanted the conversation to go away, though. I knew I was off the rails, and needed to shut up.

But I had been drinking. Quite a bit.

So I said, instead of keeping my mouth shut:

"Did Nick buy you *a lot* of jewelry?"

Lana leaned her elbow on the door and gave me a vicious glare. "What do *you* think?"

I faced the back of the passenger seat and pressed my lips together, nodding. Fair. That was fair. Nick was Nick. He had money and he liked to display it. But I was a drunk man with a bone to pick, so some forthcoming answer was not going to stop me.

"How much of it did you keep?"

Lana exhaled loudly.

"Lana?"

"I hawked it all. Except this."

"You hawked it. You hawked it all, except this ring."

It was so ridiculous even imagining Lana "hawking" something that I almost laughed in her face.

Lana looked at me again. She opened her mouth to say something, shaking her head. Then she pressed her lips together. Then, as icily as I've ever heard her say anything, she hissed, "Yes."

"That's nice, Lana. How am I supposed to take that?"

Lana was glaring hard at me now. I could see it in my peripheral vision. There was a long pause, so I had plenty of time to realize I was about to get crucified. It was unpleasant.

Lana looked straight ahead, like she was talking to the driver. "I don't know, husband. Maybe you should take it the same way I took it when you went upstairs with Brandy to the master bedroom for fifteen minutes."

She let this sit, then turned her haughty face toward me. I moved my head to look straight ahead this time, and to hide the bright red that creeps up my neck when I've been deked like a chump.

Oh, but she wasn't done. "As something that happened. That looks bad. But that *I* know has a very simple, plausible explanation, because I trust you, and I know you take your marriage vows seriously."

Stone-cold busted. My chest got tight and my limbs went numb as every last drop of blood fled them. Headed straight for my dick, which was coming to life.

"I was going to tell you about that."

Lana faced the headrest. "Of course," she said cheerfully.

Silence.

"So what was it?" she asked, digging into her purse.

"What was what?" I was keeping drunken score, and I had calculated that Lana owed me an explanation. My math was beginning to look bad, though.

"The explanation?" Lana said, taking out a compact and doing something to her face while she peered into it. "For being in a bedroom with Brandy."

I remember distinctly thinking this must be how a guy feels if he steps on a landmine and hears the click.

"Lana, that was just... you know, that was entirely Brandy, actually," I babbled, gaining momentum as I remembered the first strange moments of that encounter. "She said she was looking for... that you were looking for me. And then next thing I knew, we were up there. She said you thought you went on the tour. I swear. And then she threw herself at me." I let my head fall against the headrest.

The driver met my eyes and his head moved slightly, left to right, and back again, as his eyes briefly closed in sympathy for my problem. Every guy, he seemed to say, has stepped on his own dick like this.

Lana nodded, staring daggers at the head rest. "Yeah. Of course. The tour. So you thought: 'Tour. That sounds like my Lana!' Nothing suspicious going

on here at all. And up you went. With a fake-tit blonde floozy dressed like a fourteen-year old sneaking out to a rave."

The driver's eyes closed again. His head moved slightly side to side.

Fuck both of you, I thought. "That *is* what happened, whether you believe it or not."

Lana smiled. She looked at her lap. Then she looked at me. "Well. That sounds very bad, Chad Maxwell Robertson."

I glared at my own head rest. She had me there.

Now, I told myself fervently, was the time to shut up. Lana had made her point, and I would escape my own transgressions if I just *shut my mouth*.

"So why did you keep this ring?" I heard myself say.

"Heh." Lana barked. Her arms were folded across her chest. I was not making this bait and switch. She turned her head to me. "Well, Mr. Robertson. I tried to sell it. It's a hard piece to sell. So I put it in a box and forgot about it."

"Uh-huh. Yeah. Okay. Just one question, though, and then I'm all good. Why, out of all this supposed jewelry that Nick gave you, did he happen to ask you about this one piece? And how did that happen, again? You were admiring the pool, engaging in talk about the weather, and he said: 'Oh hey, Lana, speaking of saltwater versus chlorine, did you happen to keep that -' What was it? Engagement ring?"

Lana shook her head, smiling smugly, and did something with her hem. "Well, I don't remember exactly, but I *do* know that I wasn't in a bedroom with him alone when we had the conversation."

She was eating me for lunch, and in my drunken haze, it felt very unfair. "Do you know what I'm having a hard time with, Lana?" I continued. I hated myself for not shutting up, but Lana had activated my competitive drive.

"Do tell."

"I'm having a hard time understanding why an engagement ring was so hard to unload. You know? I myself have never have to do it, but I get the impression that diamonds in titanium settings are pretty easy to... you know, pawn, at least."

Lana shot me a look. I realized, when she did, that I had revealed that I possessed too much information, given what she had told me. I felt sick.

"Who said it was - ?"

"I just assumed. That's what Nick would buy," I said, falteringly.

Lana shifted her jaw, studying me. *You are*, her face said, *completely full of shit*.

Then she faced the seat. "It wasn't an engagement ring. *And* I'm giving it back to him."

"Right."

"How about - hey, sir, it's up here on the right, with the yellow car -how about we both agree that we each did something questionable here, and then make a deal. Okay? I won't forget about any jewelry that other men gave me, and you won't let young, blonde, barely legal women take you into bedrooms, using the excuse that they're... what did you say? Looking for *me*?" She opened the car door. "Thank you sir, I'll give you a good rating."

The driver briefly met my eyes in the rear view. He seemed mildly sympathetic. We shook heads briefly with our eyes locked in comradery.

Women. And your own dick. Two things we all trip on, buddy. Hang in there.

All of this would have been fine once I sobered up, if not for the eavesdropping and the weird mix of things Brandy had said to me.

It was true that I had done something stupid, and ultimately not acted on Brandy's very inviting... well, invitation.

And it was also true my wife's ludicrously wealthy ex-boyfriend, who happened to be my boss, had asked for her to return a piece of jewelry (that wasn't an engagement ring), that contained titanium and a diamond.

And she was going to do so.

And that she had a fairly weak reason for not having returned in the first place.

Lana, one; Chad, one.

Tie.

It was time to keep my mouth shut and not worry about any of this. Lana "avoiding" Nick was not going to be easy, and it was going to create problems, but it dovetailed nicely with my desire to avoid Brandy.

The end.

Or it should have been. Except none of it added up.

The next morning, after hours of tense non-sleeping, I rose at 4:30am after trying (half-heartedly) to arouse Lana, who seemed to be awake but

had her back turned toward me all night.

I traced a finger down her spine. Her shoulder blade dimpled with goosebumps beneath a silky red camisole strap. I pushed her hair away from her neck and moved my nose to inhale the scent of her, pressing my lips to a bump of her spine. She ceased breathing for a bit, but did not otherwise respond.

Still mad.

I got out of bed and went to make coffee.

Lana joined me at 5:30. This was way, way, earlier than Lana liked to get up. She was dressed in athleisure. Her tone was cool, but a warm current traveled through her body language. "How's your head?"

"I'm sorry about last night."

She moved closer, rippled, kissed me on the cheek. "Me, too."

We started moving around the kitchen, being overly nice when we bumped into each other. So it goes with marriage. We both wanted to put the whole thing behind us. That is what this meant, in *girlsprachen*.

I would never understand why women don't just want to fuck it away, but I suppose I'm in good company with every other man alive and dead on this planet.

"Uh, so... if you want, I can take that in to Nick today."

Lana was pouring liquid yogurt onto granola. "What?"

"The ring."

"Oh. Yeah. The, uh... That. Uh... yeah, look, it's... I don't even know where it is, to be honest. I'm going to have to dig for it. So...thanks."

Odd.

"Just give it to me when you find it."

There was a pregnant pause. Lana folded the milk carton back together like she was performing thoracic surgery. She turned, still looking at it, holding it in her hands.

"How do you feel about cheating?"

I had a mouthful of coffee going into my mouth, and I swallowed it all to get it out of the way without spitting it. It was extremely hot and my esophagus burned as it moved slowly down to my stomach, where it remained uncomfortably hot as I sputtered.

"Cheat- *what*? Where did that come from?"

Whatever glands or parts of the brain spit out adrenaline, mine went into overdrive.

She set the milk on the table. "Okay," she said, exhaling. "I haven't been... I have... more information than what I let on. About Brandy. And her... you know... escapades."

I looked shocked, because I was.

"Honey," I stammered. "I..." I shook my head emphatically, went to her, put my arms on hers. "You know I wouldn't cheat on you. You *know that*, right?"

My brain was right there, though, just like that little Microsoft paperclip, nagging at me. *Ask her about the "information."* *Why would she mention that?*

Lanashook herself and picked the milk up again, unfolding and refolding the top. "So, look..." She put one hand to her face and rubbed it. "Brandy and Dom - Brandy and Nick - they have, uh...an unconventional relationship. Kind of. So I think she maybe thought that, uh... we do, too."

She moved past me to put the milk in the refrigerator.

I leaned on the counter. Six billion things went through my head.

"How do *you* feel, Lana? About cheating?"

And why, pray tell, "cheating?" This description sounded more like consensual agreement.

I spit this comment at her. I was suddenly heated up. It felt like anger, but it wasn't exactly that.

She shut the fridge and faced it for a moment, silent. She sighed loudly.

"Okay. Look. I didn't want to tell you about this - it's... With you - and I want to state this emphatically - I am against it. I... really, I'm against it. In general. Totally. You know this. Um... but... Well, I didn't want to, like, get into this, so maybe that's why I've been acting so funny, about Dom, and this is why..." She looked up at the ceiling and sighed loudly. "So Brandy and Dom have this kind of relationship where they, uh... you know... aren't necessarily...faithful... like... sexually, I guess."

I laughed. Genuinely. What a news flash. "Uh, this is Nick you're talking about."

Did *anyone* think Nick was a faithful guy?

Lana turned to me. She was nervous. She put her hand out to the counter as she stepped toward me, watching her fingers. It made *me* unfathomably nervous.

"Yeah, so... it's not just like, Dom's a -"

A tiny bubble of rage burst like an aneurysm in my temple. "Can you call him Nick, please? Lana? Because that's who he is to me."

She looked up at me and looked crumpled. "Yeah, of course. Nick."

She stopped talking. I was incredibly sorry I'd interrupted her.

"Nick cheats on Brandy. Is that it? They have an open relationship?" I was being bold and aggressive right now. There was something just beneath the surface of this conversation that I didn't want to hear, but I didn't know what it was. My tactic was to bulldoze it.

"It's...yes. Okay? But it's a, um, very specific type of, uh... open relationship."

I set the coffee mug down. I was intrigued and fearful. "And what is that?"

She sucked her lower lip into her mouth and looked up at the ceiling.

The obvious answer here was not obvious to me at all. For the record.

That is because Lana is my wife.

Lana. She can wear her "sexy" cocktail dresses to funerals without raising any eyebrows. She wants to be a suburban soccer mom. She only has sex in the missionary position. She is... Lana.

"Lana?"

She inhaled deeply. "Have you ever heard of... uh..." she shook her hands out. "It's called, like, hotwife, I think."

She blinked at me, obviously happy to have unburdened herself of the word.

My eyes grew huge. "Cuckolding?" I practically shouted. "*Nick*? He's into that?"

Lana made a face. "Well, it's not... strictly like that... but, uh...basically."

I was so caught up in this interesting disclosure about Nick that I didn't even bother thinking through to the implications.

Then I did.

"Why- what? What are you telling me this -?"

"I'm telling you," Lana sighed, her voice shaky, her fingers working on the counter as if she wanted to peel away the granite from the top. Like it was linoleum. "Because it's not, like, your fault, I guess, that Brandy was, uh... propositioning you." She looked up from the counter and into my eyes. "That's just... their thing."

I tipped my head back and let out a groan of satisfaction.

Brandy's crazy conversation made so much more sense now.

Back to Lana. She looked perplexed, and sheepish.

"That whole thing makes so much more sense now," I told her, expecting her to be as content with the clarification as I was.

She looked astonished instead. Tipped her head, lost a beat. "You're not mad? Wait - why?"

As soon as she said this, I could see that the next logical conclusion occurred to both of us at the same time. It worked its way through our brain circuits. You could practically see it, like dye in blood vessels on an MRI, creeping along until the light went on in her eyes, and also in mine.

That *Brandy* and Nick did... whatever they did... was no surprise at all.

It explained why Brandy was hitting on me.

But if you kept right on thinking about it, you asked yourself *why* Brandy had been so presumptuous. About me, specifically.

Until you remembered the common denominator among all these people:
Lana.

"Lana," I said heavily. "You aren't telling me... you didn't *do that*, did you?"

Just saying it sounded insane. I almost laughed. Lana was going to be offended by this, and I was an idiot.

But Lana looked at her fingernails again, on the counter, scraping at nothing. She shrugged. "I didn't want to tell you about it," she sniffled.

She was starting to cry.

I went to her. I pulled her into my arms. I had an erection, and didn't want her to know. It was, to say the least, awkward. My head had spun off my neck long ago, and into orbit. This wasn't happening. It was too preposterous. I set to work trying to make Lana stop crying, because that was intolerable.

"I... Lana, hey, look, it's... it's in the past," I told her. Bravely. Falling on my sword.

That wasn't what I wanted to say.

It's what I was supposed to say.

It was the right thing to say.

Inside, I was in denial about the nightmare that seemed to be unfolding right in front of me.

Lana was really crying now, blubbering. "I've wanted to tell you for so long, but I thought... I'm so ashamed of it, and I just thought, oh well, you know, I just wouldn't... but then Dom was there, and he's your boss. I talked

to him, at salsa, and he said, like, don't worry about it, he wouldn't say anything to you. I've been feeling guilty forever, you know, having a secret from you, and I just... he just...and that thing with Brandy... so I decided I had to tell you." She sniffled, limp with the effort of having let out a bottled-up secret at long last. "But it's all in the past, I want you to know that."

She looked up at me. I hadn't moved a muscle. "It's why I broke up with him." She wiped her nose. Lowered her eyes. Her face was pink, the stain spreading high on her cheekbones and down to her jawline.

I wanted, more than anything in the world, to have sex with Lana just then.

It was one of those sexual impulses that felt out of my control. It was base, filthy, a shameful impulse.

I twisted so Lana wouldn't feel my ideas out through the fabric of my joggers. I embraced her and told her it was okay. If it was really in the past, it was really in the past. I was glad she broke up with Nick. This was all a long time ago.

I had plenty more to say.

But my smarts, at long last, kicked in.

And I kept my mouth shut.

Chapter Six

Nick pointed his finger at me and squinted, grinning.

"She told you." He slapped his hands on the desk and looked up at the ceiling, delighted with himself. "I knew it. That's Lana all the way. She just can't keep it in. I'm actually surprised, buddy, that she made it this long." He was shaking his head. He smirked at me.

And then, as is typical of Nick, he made it about himself. He stretched his fingers out and then linked them behind his head. "What can I say? I dig it. A lot of high-powered executives do." He arched an eyebrow. "And you aren't...?"

"No."

I said this quickly. I was on the back foot. Nick had taken one look at me and then said, "She told you." I wasn't prepared for this onslaught. Nick seemed to think this was no big deal. He even seemed to be happy to be able to talk about it.

Nick shrugged. "Don't knock it 'til you try it, man."

"I'm good."

Nick wagged a finger at me. "See. You think that. Naturally." He leaned over the desk, his arms draped on the top. "This is what people don't get, though. You know? This is a basic instinct. It's primal shit. You have no idea what a fucking rush it is, seeing your woman get just *fucked* senseless -"

"Okay," I said, putting my hands on my knees. "I just popped in to tell you I just got off the phone with Mike -"

"Uh-huh. And he's in. Sure."

Nick had the most punch-able look on his face. He was off the topic of business, and on to this new topic.

"Lana is looking for your... ring," I said, to have something to say.

"Wow. Wow. I did not see that coming. Wait..." Nick smiled coyly. "Hey man. Are you guys using that thing?"

I have no idea what I looked like when he said that. But inside, I went cold.

He held his hands up in the air. "Hey. Seriously. You know what, if that's getting put to good use, on Lana... then hey, you know. Keep it. That's..." Nick was looking at me weird now. His smile became somehow vulgar. Greasy. "I'm good with that."

Keep. Your. Mouth. Shut.

By now, of course, I was realizing that the "ring" was not a ring. Hence Lana's strange answers, Nick's incongruent conversation. They had looked at me funny when I said "ring," but then they'd just moved forward in the conversation.

I was pondering why that was. What could it actually be? What did they choose to believe I'd said instead? "Thing?"

"So you don't need it back?" I asked, to carry on the proxy conversation with Nick.

Nick looked at me like I had twenty heads. "Man, to be honest, I was just kind of... poking the bear, you know? Like, Lana's trying to tell me she's all reformed. The way she *dresses* now, you know? It's so... it just wasn't believable."

He paused, a smile on his face.

"But this makes it all make sense. Yeah, no, I uh... I never wanted it back." He laughed. "It's not like it's going to fit, you know, just anyone." He winked at me. "It just makes me happy she kept it. I can tell you that, right? You get it. It's going to good use. Yeah, and Brandy... I'll just get a new one."

I had no idea what Nick was talking about. Just a dark feeling that he knew things about my wife that I didn't, that those things were sexual, and that something lurked inside of Lana that I had never in a million years seen coming.

But Nick didn't know that. And I didn't want him to.

"Uh...okay. I'll let Lana know that."

Nick grinned. Something gleamed in his eyes. "It's nice, huh? Fuck. My dick is getting hard just thinking about it."

I stared at him.

"Take it easy," Nick told me, grinning again. "And actually, Lana taught me an important lesson. You can tell her that."

"I...huh?"

"Don't put a - yeah, not the lesson she wanted me to learn, but she doesn't have to know that." He chuckled. "What I learned, actually, is: don't put a diamond in those things."

Nick laughed again. He shook his head. He seemed to momentarily become wistful. "But let her think, you know..." he looked up at me. "Ah, whatever. You know what I mean. That I learned my 'actual lesson.'""

"Uh...yeah," I said, keeping up my ruse. "And that was... what?"

Nick snorted. "Jesus, man. To be like you, I guess. Discreet. God. Do you even talk to *her* about this?"

I gave him a blank look, not because I thought it was tactical, but because it was all I could do. My mind was racing, trying to detect what was really being said here without giving away how out of the loop I was.

Nick laughed. "Right." Then he smiled, like we shared something in common. Like a disease diagnosis. "If *you* ever need to talk, though," Nick said, grinning lasciviously, "Buddy, I am *all ears*."

"I will... keep that in mind."

"All ears." Nick's phone was ringing and he'd answered it and held it to his ear just before he said this. I gestured that I was leaving by hooking my thumb behind me, and left.

"What is it?"

Lana went pale. Her cheerful smile faded and she set her paper bag of groceries on the counter. She did not, I noted, ask what I was talking about.

It was the first thing out of my mouth when she came through the door. No context.

But she knew.

Taking items from the grocery bag one by one, setting them on the counter, her face tight, she spoke as though she were speaking to the eggs,

the celery, the kale, one by one:

"Did you go looking for it?"

"No."

"You talked to Nick about it?"

"Not exactly."

Lana met my eyes. A cold irritation was in them.

"He said a bunch of stuff. That I did not solicit. That stuff gave me the impression that this 'thing' is not a ring."

"I told you that."

"You told me it wasn't an engagement ring."

Lana removed a block of cheese. "Well. It isn't."

Lana was being cryptic. This was not Lana's style. And it had twinges of betrayal in it.

"So what is it?"

Lana lifted her eyes. "What did Nick say to you?"

I closed my eyes. "Lana, I have no idea. But that's not what I want. I don't want the answer you're going to give me only if Nick said something. I want the answer to my question."

Lana looked exasperated. "Well. I'm not really sure if I can tell you that, if Nick... like, maybe he doesn't want you to know."

I was now becoming enraged. Who in the fuck cared what Nick thought? I was her husband, not Nick.

I almost shouted this at her, but I controlled myself.

"Lana. Nick is the one who told me that this thing existed. He *thinks* I know what it is. I do not. You have been misleading me about it. And so now I want to know. I want to see it. What is this piece of jewelry that you kept, that Nick doesn't want back anymore?"

Her eyes went wide. "He doesn't?" She exhaled. "Great. That's the end of it, then."

She sighed at my expression.

She then became very animated, lighting up like a great idea had occurred to her. "This is so like Nick. It's *so like him*. Ugh. He never wanted it back. He just... I mean, this is literally why I broke up with him. He just can't stop thinking about this shit, he's completely obsessed."

She put her hands to her face, turned red, and started crying again.

I felt bad about this. Seriously.

But now I just absolutely had to know what this thing was.

First things first, though, I had to comfort my wife.
Even if I didn't know what the fuck she was crying about. Not exactly.

I stared at it.

I'm a pretty mechanically-savvy guy, in that I can figure out how most mechanical shit works.

Like most men, flesh mechanisms eluded me a little bit, though.

So I could see, theoretically, how the item in the box, set on velvet, was supposed to work *mechanically*. What I could not do was make it work, in my mind, with Lana's flesh.

"How did - ?"

"I'm not - I can't wear it. Anymore. Obviously."

My eyes went to Lana's crotch, and my mind began to render a detailed, detailed visual of her vulva. My nerve endings offered up phantoms of sensations: the feel of the inner lips on the tip of my tongue, the hard shape of her erect clit beneath it. Wouldn't there be *some* tell-tale trace of this?

A very certain kind of humiliation rolled over me: I did not know my wife's pussy very well.

I lifted my eyes and met Lana's.

In them was disappointment. It cut through me like a knife.

"This is exactly why I didn't want to tell you about this," Lana told me, very annoyed. She snapped the box shut and held it out to me. "Here. Take it. Give it to Nick. I don't care. But I never want to talk about this again."

I didn't take the box. Lana wagged it, became annoyed, and then tossed it on the bed. She was getting hot. Latina hot. She hardly ever got like this, but when she did, she let out a long stream of absolutely unintelligible ranting.

Not in Spanish. I wish. No, in English, with a Latina cadence.

It was terrifying, humiliating, and also very hot.

We were also talking about a chastity piercing. An elaborate, well-made piece of jewelry that had evidently - I was guessing here - been attached to the hood of Lana's clit, and closed over her hole by two additional rings that locked closed, knitting her precious pussy together.

These two things were hanging in the air - Lana's fury, and a genital jewelry piece that had either locked her ex-boyfriend, my boss, out of her

pussy - or that her ex-boyfriend, my boss, had asked her to wear to keep other men out of her pussy.

That she had worn, evidently. And kept. After ending her cuckolding relationship with Nick. My boss.

At least, this what I thought was happening here. I really couldn't be certain of anything anymore.

My dick was as hard as it had ever been.

Her eyes went to my crotch.

Then she rolled them. "You're just like him. You know that?"

"Lana, what the fuck?" I said, raising my voice. "You're the one who played sex games with your ex-boyfriend and kept the fucking..." I gestured at the piercing, not sure what to call it. "After...what? Having sex with other men? How many? And you never told me about that. Me. Your husband."

"Well. Now you know! Okay? And why do you think I didn't tell you about it? Because of this. This right here. You're just like Nick: you want the details, it's all you can think about, you're going to want to talk about it every second of the day. So you want to know? Okay! Here it is. Yes. I fucked other guys when I was with Nick. He watched me sometimes, sometimes he didn't. And I *liked* it. I liked fucking these guys, these guys with big dicks. I liked doing things with strangers that I would never do with someone I love!"

She was on a roll, but came to a sudden halt. As I stared at her, stunned beyond belief, she seemed to veer in another direction behind her eyes.

"But I also liked living the rest of my life. But that's never good enough, is it? No. Nick had to talk about it all the time, ask me for details all the time, play these games all the time. It never ended. What would I do next? When would I do it? You know what would be hot, Lana? How about this, Lana? It was all too... just all too much!"

There are two kinds of smarts in this world...

They are both utterly overridden by testosterone.

"You *liked* fucking - ?"

Lana let out a roar at the ceiling and blew past me out of the room. Down the hallway, to the master bedroom. She slammed the door. "It's like you aren't even listening to a thing I say!" she yelled, from behind the door, after a dramatic pause.

I was listening.

As usual, though, I was not hearing what Lana believed she had said.

In all honesty, I didn't know what Lana could possibly have expected me to focus on in that conversation, other than what I did.

She fucked other guys. She liked it. She wore a chastity piercing. She played devious sexual games with my boss Nick, and they had involved piercing her genitalia and fucking other guys with huge dicks.

I was listening. Rapt with attention.

I had a hard cock. What did she expect?

It wasn't like Lana didn't know I occasionally watched some porn and got hard while doing it. It was sex. It was erotic.

Two insects having sex was erotic. A ball of mating snakes was erotic.

I am a fucking heterosexual man.

All heterosexual sex is erotic.

All sex with my wife is erotic.

Finding out my sweet, conservatively dressed, cupcake of a wife who was going to be the model soccer mom in the suburbs also had a twisted, slutty side to her?

What was I supposed to do?

Not find that erotic?

That's exactly what I supposed to do.

After a lot of crying and confusing talk, I gathered that the reason Lana had broken up with Nick and sworn off hotwifing (or hot-girlfriending) was because Nick had become obsessed with it.

Naturally, I wanted to explore - in detail - the boundaries and depths of the interior of all of that.

But at least I knew now that Lana... did not.

I was of two minds about it. Or maybe ten.

I am Lana's husband, and I don't deserve to be and I never have. All I want is for Lana to be happy.

But marriage confers, in my mind, a certain amount of entitlement. Entitlement to know about your wife. About what she did, about who she fucked, about what's really going on inside her mind.

My reaction, furthermore, to this whole idea, was not what I expected. Don't get me wrong: our sex life was absolutely fine by me. Lana was the

most delicious, perfect, gourmet vanilla ice cream in the world. Our sex life was not sizzling and daring, but Lana was so beautiful and perfect that it didn't matter.

Finding out, though, that your gourmet vanilla ice cream was sort of... faking being vanilla, or had it in them to be Cherry Garcia... opened a whole can of worms. Worms that twisted and tensed in my groin. I couldn't help it. I wanted to taste that other flavor.

I wanted to at least hear a description of that flavor.

And this also called everything into question.

Was Lana truly satisfied with our sex life? Was she just bottled up, pretending to be someone she wasn't? Would she explode one day and cheat on me? Was Nick's obsessive streak the *only* reason she left him... in which case she maybe still pined for him, and his money and alpha-maleness? Was I just a second, reliable choice made to safeguard against getting hurt? Or maybe Nick wasn't anything like that.

Anything was seemingly possible. Lana, my wife, was a little slut who wore genital jewelry for her ex-boyfriend, my boss.

But also, thoughts more base than those scuttled around in my head.

What did Lana think about while she was fucking me in the missionary position? What did she masturbate to? What was it like to be locked out of her pussy? What did that piercing look like, locked down over her clit and her hole? Did she make Nick clean her up, locked out of her cunt that was oozing with another man's cum?

Was I man enough to do something like that?

Or had Lana kept all of this from me not because she didn't crave it, but because she thought I couldn't deal with it? Did she think I was less of a man than Nick?

The only thing, after all of this, and my promise - to get her to stop crying - not to get obsessed with it or press her for details, that I could even remember Lana saying, specifically, was this:

I fucked other guys. And I liked it.

I slept in the guest room. That was my choice. I could tell Lana thought that meant something other than what it meant, but the real reason I did it was because I was so fucking hard, and wanted to fuck Lana in a way that I never fucked her before, that I figured it was better not to go there.

I jerked off, instead.

I couldn't talk to Lana about it honestly. I didn't know what she wanted my reaction to be, but "turned on" struck me as incorrect. I knew she didn't want to provide me the details. I knew she didn't want me to be "obsessed." But I was.

Obsessed.

It's not like I could just talk to Nick about it. There was no doubt in my mind that Nick would have loved nothing more than to sit me down and narrate in explicit detail all the nasty things my wife had done in bed with other men, and also - why not? - with him.

But that would be a humiliation of epic proportions. Sitting where? In a chair? While my boss the alpha-dog rattles on about the cum pouring out of my wife's pussy? Would I burble, "did she ever do anal?" and sit there while he told me about it? Or would I sit there with the question burning a hole through my boxers and my mind, and slink away without the answer because I was too much of a pussy to ask?

Either way, it would be a nightmare.

Also, if Lana ever found out about it, she'd probably leave me, too. See parts one through 475 of the two-hour-long, sobbing list of complaints about Nick.

Shutting my mouth, yet again, was the smart choice.

But how many men dutifully shut their mouths and rein in their impulses, only to have their dick rob them of all the oxygenated blood in their body and do all the thinking for them?

Finding out what Lana did - beyond just wear a piercing, that I could not believe I hadn't detected a trace of having been there, on her fucking cunt and screw other men while Nick watched - became the net activity of my brain.

It was all I could think about.

I couldn't initiate sex with her, because I was convinced she would pick up on this. Because I couldn't trust myself not to head down there under the guise of eating her out (well, it wouldn't be a guise entirely) and then start inspecting her for traces of these piercing holes.

What did I want to see them for, anyway?

They had been there. She had told me that.

I wanted her to put it on. I wanted her to tell me I couldn't fuck her and see how that felt. I fantasized about her opening her legs to show me her pussy and seeing white, creamy cum ooze from behind the jail bars affixed to her hole.

I didn't *want* to be like this. I wanted to *want* to be, to actually be, the man Lana needed and wanted. A man who could find out something like this and move on bravely with his life without thinking about it ever again. The past is the past. I married her, I won.

Did I want to be a cuckold? Did I want Lana to be a slut? Who knew?

The problem wasn't even that: the problem was that I couldn't stop thinking about it. Did it make me a better man in Lana's eyes if I didn't? Or did it make me a lesser man, a trade-off? Images of me sitting in a chair and watching another man fuck my wife came in like a tsunami, every second of every day.

So Lana, obviously, sensed that something was wrong. I wasn't acting normal around her. I didn't know what she wanted me to do, who she wanted me to be.

I couldn't be honest with her, I couldn't be dishonest with her.

So I worked late every night.

And that is how I came to witness Brandy and Nick, picking out a guy together. And later, Brandy fucking them. Both.

Chapter Seven

The way our office is organized is mostly about displaying money and signaling what people think they want in a hedge fund company: reassuring, solid oak that reminds people of old, dividends-in-perpetuity wealth, infused gently with Nick's Gordon Gekko vibes. The furniture is heavy, the cables hidden, the whole place looks like it would take decades to pack up, and was purchased in the carefree, no-expense-spared way that only real money can buy. We have real art. We have ten-thousand dollar rugs. Our ferns are real and cared for by plant specialists, not the night cleaning crew.

Nick's office is in the middle of all this, big glass panels between wood columns, implying transparency and omnipotence on Nick's part. He oversees it all. We work in a big area where our cubicles are delineated by tasteful rug and fern partitions, not tacky cubicle walls.

People walk through this place at all hours, but when someone like Brandy Mahoney glides through in a semi-transparent dress, looking like she disembarked ten minutes ago from a three-day sex party on a yacht, her very real gold and diamond jewelry clanging with her steps - you take notice.

You don't look up from the very important work you're doing, but you do notice. Your attention floats away with her, into Nick's office. You notice that she sits on the desk and her long, young legs are dangling all over the place. Her dress was more like lingerie. She was a beautiful creature whose every single gesture screamed "I want to be fucked."

They were intimately involved with her phone. They were passing it back and forth, Nick smiling and working his hand up Brandy's legs, beneath her skirt. Brandy laughing and smiling and showing him some other thing on his phone, which must have been great, given that he was more interested in it than what lay between her legs.

I was there with very little to actually do. I still hadn't decided how to face Lana. I believed that Lana probably wanted everything to just go back to normal, but I didn't trust myself to be able to do that. My mind was completely infected with sexual paranoia and obsession. I didn't think I could pull it off.

So I could have left, and I probably should have.

I just couldn't get myself out of the chair.

They started having a playful argument. Brandy was cooing, "No, oh my God," and then laughing. Nick's hands were way, way up her skirt now.

I was in their line of sight: everything is. It wasn't like they didn't know I was there. It seemed to me like they might start fucking any minute. I had a hard-on. I felt sick. I kept picturing Lana in Brandy's place, sitting on the desk, letting Nick put his fingers anywhere he wanted to, laughing and tittering.

I suppose it felt like a window to the past. Brandy was Nick's girlfriend now, and Brandy had the same relationship with Nick that Lana had evidently had. I got so busy imposing Lana's likeness on Brandy that I practically believed it was her in there, instead of Brandy. The illusion intoxicated me, made me forget where I was or what I was doing.

Pretty soon, I was just full-on turned and staring at them.

Brandy saw me as she tossed her hair and laughed an objection at Nick. I went cold with that slamming feeling of getting caught. But I was paralyzed.

"Well," Brandy giggled. "Why don't we ask Chad?" She looked up, directly at me. Nick got a very amused expression on his face. "Oh Chaaaaa-aaaaaaaad," Brandy called out to me. "Come here, we need to settle something."

"Yeah, Crobs, get in here." To Brandy: "He's going to agree with me." Nick yelled again. "Chad! Come - Brandy, give me that- come in here. I need a man's opinion."

If I hadn't been fantasizing so completely that Brandy was actually Lana, I would have said, "I'm good."

But I didn't. I stood up and walked, with a mixture of caution, lust, fury, and intrigue, toward this portal into my wife's past.

Brandy moved her legs so they were hanging over the side of the desk closest to me. She made a big show of crossing them slowly, so I could see up her skirt. I didn't see much, though. She snatched the phone from Nick as she did and started swiping at it while she spoke.

"So Nick thinks," she purred, with a very GenZ accent, "that I- well, wait, here's the background. So I like *this* guy..." She flipped the phone toward me.

There was nothing but brutal male pelvis and dick on the screen. A very pale, thin man, by the looks of it, and a huge, huge cock resting in his hand.

"Oops, that's the one - here, sorry." Brandy slipped the phone back and swiped before presenting another picture, this time of a very tan, very muscular torso, and another dick - not as large - being suspended casually by a large and wiry hand.

"*That's* the guy I like. And then..." she swiped back to the pale man with the huge dick. "Nick says I'll have a better time with this guy."

"Because of his dick," Nick added, in a know-it-all tone.

Brandy let the phone droop in her limp wrist as she turned to Nick. "But he's so pasty, Nicky. I mean..." she lifted the photo and assessed it again. "It is... big. But that's not everything. And this guy has..." she became absorbed in the phone again. "He's like... I like his muscles."

They both looked at me. Sincerely.

Brandy was oozing all over the desk, her face the exact kind of face every man dreams about. Her eyes were wet with interest and desire for my opinion, and the opinion she wanted was about sex.

When in Rome.

I pointed casually toward the phone. "You're going to fuck one of these guys?" I asked her.

Brandy broke out into laughter and patted me. "Oh my God, Chad, you're so cute."

"He's adorable," Nick confirmed blandly. Brandy was facing me, so Nick held up two fingers. "Go for the big dick," he mouthed.

Brandy swatted at him without looking behind her. "Don't listen to him. I want your real opinion." Only then did she glance behind her at Nick. "*Chad* knows it isn't all about the dick size."

"Oh, but it is, sweetie," Nick said, reaching for her ass. He leaned in to kiss it, or maybe just inhale. "You know that's what you really want."

"Chad?" Brandy said, after a pause long enough to confuse me for a moment.

I inhaled deeply. She was asking for my *opinion*.

"Is there, uh, any reason you have to... I don't know. Choose?"

"No," Nick said, at once, smiling.

"Yes," Brandy said, and then slapped Nick playfully again. "Yes, yes there is," she argued forcefully, with a giggle, as if Nick had continued arguing with her. She looked at me. "*This guy*," she explained, tapping her nail on the screen, which I couldn't see, "is only into the one-on-one. And *this guy*," she swiped and tapped, again out of my view, "is only in town tonight. Ohhhhh. I like them *both*."

"What do you think, Chad?" Nick said, leaning back in his chair with his hands on the back of his head. "Would you stick around, if you were banging someone's girl and some other guy showed up to join? Be honest."

"Baby, he's very specific. See? He *bolded* it."

Nick was looking at me.

"Well," I said.

This was all so far out in outer space, I guess I decided to just run with it. "I wouldn't be, you know... fucking some other guy's woman. So."

Nick found this incredibly funny. "Yeah, yeah, we know that. But pretend. You're balls deep in... Brandy here, and some other guy shows up. What do you do?"

"He's going to get mad," Brandy said.

"He's not," Nick said, before she even finished her sentence. "Chad. Back me up."

Brandy was shaking her head.

What would I do, if I was fucking some woman in front of a man, and another guy showed up to fuck her, too?

"Uh...truthfully, guys? I just do not fucking know. I've never been in this position."

"That's your own fault," Brandy said, smiling, leaning toward me.

"Knock it off, Brandy, Chad here is not a bull."

Brandy fluttered her eyes. "That is sooo too bad."

I am a notorious comedian when I get into bad situations. "Well, I don't have that big of a dick, I can tell you that," I quipped.

Brandy tossed her head back, along with all of her magnificent blond hair. "Ughhhhh," she groaned. "That's what I'm trying to explain, it isn't all about that."

"Don't believe her, she's a size queen," Nick said. He hadn't moved from his relaxed position. He was enjoying himself.

The reason I work for Nick is because I want money. My skills come in handy, but this is not what I was born to do. I'm a negotiator, not a flat-out liar.

And that is my excuse for what I did next.

"So...is there some reason you can't just... I don't know? Schedule them one right after the other?"

I said this mostly because I could. Because somehow, the universe had deigned it the day that I was going to get to stand in my boss's office, with a hot chick on his desk asking me who she should fuck, and I got to say: "schedule them one right after the other" without – likely – getting slapped.

Brandy went quiet and looked down at Nick. Nick was smiling like he was very proud of me.

He shot a hand out and pointed at me. "This man. You see? This is why I love you, Chad. Logistical mind."

"Great," I said. "So glad I could be of -"

Brandy shot out her arm and gripped mine. "Chad. Look. Nicky filled me in on the whole thing. So maybe... I don't know... baby?" She fluttered her eyelashes at Nick. She leaned over, rolling to her side, showing me a large swatch of her uncovered ass, enough to tell me she wasn't even wearing underwear. She played with Nick's hair while she whispered in his ear. But it was loud. "Maybe Chad can come along?"

"Oh boy," I said, stuffing my hands in my pockets. I did a half turn, but I admit it was half-assed. "I'm gonna -"

"No, no, no, not to - Chad, wait." Brandy slipped off the desk and got very close to me. She smelled like perfume but somehow also of sex, and her caged, animal sexiness radiated all over me. "Not to *do anything*. Just, you know... watch." She blinked at me ingenuously. "*Lana* shouldn't get to have *all* the fun."

Then she giggled. "Also, we could wager on it."

Danger.

Danger, danger, danger.

You know when it's right there in front of you. You imagine yourself turning around, cheerfully waving goodbye. You try to picture yourself in the car, the door closed, the scent of pussy gone, your breath leaving your lungs in a shudder, only the sweet sense of victory over your own dick to assuage the pain in your balls.

You're a good man, if you can just turn around and get to your car. You can start the engine, drive home, and fuck your own wife (hopefully).

But Brandy wasn't asking me to *fuck* her.

And I had fantasized in such detail, out of morbid curiosity, that image of Lana over Brandy.

And I was so desperate to have a window into the past, to see what my wife was like before. Back when she was, evidently, against all evidence, *like Brandy*.

Sex was blaring at me in all directions. I am a man.

Lana was at home, but Lana was sort of weirdly pissed at me.

I also felt justifiably aggrieved. She had kept a secret from me: she had been a slut. She was withholding from me what she'd given freely- and enthusiastically - to Nick.

And now Nick's girlfriend, who was hot as all fuck, was offering to stand in as a surrogate and let me peek in on all the things I'd been turning around in my head and dying to know more about: *without me having to ask Lana about them*.

She was just asking me to watch.

And importantly, Brandy, whether she knew it or not, had touched that nerve inside every man that overrides almost all common sense: she had managed to introduce that most alluring of male competition: gambling. And a matter of fairness and sportsmanship - Lana *shouldn't* have all the fun.

Click, click, click. The dominoes fell, one after the other. I began to construct the elaborate house of justification cards:

My wife wasn't fucking me tonight. My wife had been a slut for another man and didn't want to discuss it. My wife had secrets and she never would have shared them. I wasn't really cheating, My boss was egging me on. A blond with no underwear wanted me to watch her getting fucked. Someone had mentioned placing bets. It was the window into the past that might satisfy my aching curiosity.

"Come on Croooobs," Nick said, fully aware that I had already tipped over. He rubbed his hands together. "We'll get a steak. We'll place some bets. You're in, aren't you?"

I was being plied with steak, gambling, sex...

Brandy was already giggling. "Wait, wait, what are we betting on, again?"

Nick grinned at her and beckoned her close to him. "Your sweet ass, baby."

It was my last chance. They started fooling around, basically, right in front of me. I could have easily walked out then. Brandy would have frowned, and poo-pooed it, but neither of them truly seemed to care if I went or not.

"Where are we going?" I asked.

"What did you tell Lana?"

Nick was destroying a steak in a way that defies description. It occurred to me, watching him eat, that I had never actually seen him eat a meal before. He was like an animal: the steak was bloody, and he was shoving fantastically-sized chunks of it into his mouth and chewing only enough to ensure he didn't choke. He was slicing the next piece as he chewed.

This question - about Lana - was the first thing he'd said to me since we arrived at The Cut, a restaurant that I sincerely hoped Nick was paying for. Everything else had been Nick's typical banter: the wine, the waitress, the guy he knew who eat here every single day and a rough estimate of how much that cost him (\$5k a month - the guy was a huge tipper and drank pricey wine).

It was as if eating a steak dinner at The Cut while his girlfriend sought out another man in the hotel upstairs was something he did every Wednesday night.

I hadn't told Lana anything. I texted her to say I was working late with Nick, that we would probably grab dinner, and that she shouldn't wait up for me.

No problem, Lana had written. I have to stay late, too.

In ordinary times - the before-times, when I had known my wife as a bubbly, sweet, wholesome Latina - this conversation would have seemed perfectly innocuous.

Now, it was steeped with innuendo.

Was Lana's "staying late, too" a sarcastic statement? Did she know I wasn't "staying late" as insinuated, but "staying late" as I really was - involved in something out-of-bounds?

Did that mean that Lana was also "staying late" with another man?

This was the only thing I was thinking about as I stewed in the chair across from Nick, staring at the way the man was eating his steak. I'd ordered a filet Mignon but felt mildly ill. It was sliced open and bleeding all over the plate. The only thing I'd consumed was wine.

I shrugged in answer to Nick's question. "Staying late."

This amused Nick, and he smiled through the gnashing of his teeth. Very dramatically, he shook out his napkin and wiped his mouth. It took me a second to realize he was laughing, and the napkin was less to clean up the watery blood dripping from his chin than to hide his chuckle.

Or emphasize it. His eyebrows shot up in high arches. "Okay," he said.

"What does that mean?"

Nick grinned at me and stabbed at his salad. He was shaking his head. "Look man," he said, a chunk of steak still requiring some shifting of his mouth, muffling his voice. "I'm obviously the last person on earth to give anyone advice on Lana Cuervo, but..."

A ripple of unease electrified my heart every time Nick referred to Lana as "Lana Cuervo." It's not like it was the first time I was hearing the vague allusion to sex in her name. It really would have worked as a porn name, a stripper name, the name of a drink. It was sexy. In Nick's mouth it acquired sleaziness.

"But, what?" I asked, staring at the amassing of salad on his fork.

Nick grinned. He shrugged. He remained uncommitted and nonchalant. "Nothing man. You do you. She's reformed, as you say." He looked skyward. "Unfortunately."

He stared at me over the tines stuffed with lettuce. "Or is she?"

I gave him no reply, visual or otherwise. My heart was pounding.

"Man, this cannot seriously be the first time you're hearing of this," Nick said, lifting his wine glass after chewing up his salad. He swirled it. "I mean, does it *actually* come as a shock to you?"

I didn't answer. The only thing more humiliating than finding out your wife was actually a sex bomb slut was having to admit to her ex-boyfriend that she didn't tell you anything about it.

Nick gulped some wine. He made a loud "Ahhh" sound. "That's kinda hot," he remarked, thoughtfully looking off into the distance.

"So...where is Brandy now?" I asked, partly out of curiosity and partly to change the subject. Nick fell into reverie sometimes about Lana and the situation got me hot under the collar, vaguely aroused, and generally made me uncomfortable.

Nick waved his hand. "Upstairs. She doesn't... you know. Want to go in on a full stomach. If you know what I mean."

I both did - my imagination was sailing in a sewer of implications, all of them nasty and hot - and didn't. I'd done some "research" since this all came up, and this predilection – hotwifing - was actually pretty common. There was, in fact, an entire ecosystem of young men with huge dicks out there offering this very service to couples.

It set me on edge, though, rifling through it all. Before, it would have fascinated me, as fantasy and curiosity more than anything. Knowing the precious little I knew about Lana and Nick, though, it was also threatening.

There was no end of cock on the internet, cock you could order up like Brandy and Nick just had, cock that would happily come for my own wife. Cock that had seemed safely locked out of our lives, and now seemed like barbarians at the gate.

Barbarians I had a mild interest in seeing charge through.

One of the reasons Nick is as successful as he is, is because he's a genius at distilling what other people *actually* want. He can detect it like shark can smell the tiniest drop of blood in the water. Who knows how he does it? It may have merely flickered in my eye for an instant.

I could see Nick's own eyes glimmer with recognition. He got this look all the time in my presence. Right before he went in - relentlessly cheerful, fun like the devil - for the kill.

He forcefully threw his fork into the plate of half-devoured meat, grinning at me, and leaned over the table. He was drawing me in, the way he drew in clients. It was like a tractor beam. No amount of repeating to myself that this man had fucked my wife, and that my wife had fucked other men for Nick, could keep me from leaning in to him.

"You want to know what Lana did, don't you?"

The trick of the devil, as they say, is in his charisma. So understand: Nick was *pulling it off* asking this question. I *did* want to know what Lana did, of

course. Somehow Nick was managing to ask me in a way that made me want to say yes, rather than punch him.

Nick smiled at my non-answer. He pointed his knife at me. "You know, I got into this the same way as you?"

I beamed incredulity.

"See, this is the thing. You've got what society is telling you, you know: don't get disrespected by your woman, keep her pussy away from everybody else. But inside, you know you have some other thoughts. Those are your instincts, man. You think, in like, cave-man times, everyone could afford to be monogamous?" He tore into his steak and stuffed more in his mouth. "No way," he said, chewing. "Women... I was just reading this the other day. Their vaginas are *hostile* to sperm. Babies are like tumors. Some men are shooting blanks. You know? Some people are just incompatible. Having sex takes all this energy. Why do you think men want to do it all the time, then? Why do they like watching other people fuck? Why would you have this brain that says fuck, fuck, fuck, do it this way, do it that way, and take up all your precious mind-energy?"

I blinked. Seriously? "Uh...reproduction?"

Nick was already dismissing my answer before it was fully out of my mouth. "Yeah, no shit. But why all the *kink*? Why don't female human go into heat like cats and rub themselves all over us, and we're in and out and done with it and don't think about again until another cat is rubbing her scent all over us?"

I radiated annoyance across the table. As if I had never wondered why so much of my mind and work ethic had been drained off into a lake of non-thoughts and time wasted on pussy.

Nick smiled. He had the answer. He was smugly going to impart it upon me. "Because our bodies and minds are still back in the cave-man days. Men have to have sex over and over again, so women don't have, like, an allergic reaction to our seed. You've got to take your best shot, in cave-man times, and just get every female pregnant that you can, but like... it's a team effort back then. So your mind..." Nick pointed fervently at his own head with the knife, "is programmed to find it erotic, other men fucking your mate. If you feel a pull to do something, some sexual desire, man, it always has some reason for being there. An evolutionary reason. So I say, why fight it, you know?"

I was open-mouthed.

Nick's knife went back toward my face. "I know you're thinking, who wants their girlfriend to get knocked up with some other guy's kid, right? And you're right, we don't. And we know *now*, like, how babies are actually made and all this shit. We have fertility treatments. But all of that..." Nick waved his hand. "That's not in the DNA. Driving us. Our brains were wired before all this knowledge got here." He smiled. "The women have this in their heads, too, as you know. They love it. It's their instinct just as much as it is yours."

Nick gave a self-satisfied grin and lifted his wine glass to clink the base against mine. "All you gotta do is just *access* that."

I've watched Nick sell people total bullshit. I know what kind of guy he is: silver-tongued, influencing. Charismatic.

Nonetheless, against my better angels, his shtick was making sense.

Or I was letting it make sense.

And why?

Because Nick knew what I also knew, and more importantly, he knew how act on it:

It's very easy to sell people on what they already want, even if that thing is dangerous, or ludicrous, or rationally a terrible idea.

All they are really looking for is someone to tell them it's okay to want it.

Then you just find out what kind of person they are, what kind of excuse they crave.

Nick knew me: he knew I was ever-rational deep down inside. I make things add up on paper and speak with a golden tongue, usually for regulators. Nick bullshits and does magic tricks, and then I have to make it function so we don't all go to jail.

So I knew this whole spiel was bullshit curated just for me.

But Nick knew something more important than that: he knew it was what I wanted to hear, because he knew me better than I even knew myself.

"Ah. You're thinking, I have Lana all wrong," Nick said, after a pause that made me think he'd be on to the next thing like he usually was. Nick never lingered long on anything. Drop the bomb, move on, was his motto. Let them reel themselves in.

He looked up at me, smiling, a piece of raw steak in front of his mouth. "But trust me, I don't."

I sipped my wine. "She doesn't see it that way," I told him.

Nick stopped chewing. He grinned. He chewed some more. "Crobs. Okay man. Lana?"

"Why did she break up with you, then? And never show any - and I mean, *any*- interest in this?"

Nick chewed more slowly, studying me, grinning. "Dude. Seriously?"

I was serious.

Nick shrugged. He had a look on his face that I recognized. He had said too much, more than he intended to. He was scrambling to cover it up. What did he come up with?

In a voice that barely convinced even himself: "She felt *guilty*. It's a sin. She's Catholic. I ran my mouth too much, it made her nervous. That's my fault." He started in on his salad again. "But I've seen Lana in action, Crobs, and I'm sorry, but that chick was *in-to-it*. That just doesn't... go away."

His eyes lit up while he stared into his memories, just over my shoulder in the distance.

Guilt clung to me, now that it had been mentioned. I shouldn't have been there, doing this illicit thing. Listening to Nick talk about my wife like this. Lana would be pissed. This was vaguely betrayal. Of something.

I was thinking my own thoughts, seeing my own, imagined past in which Lana was a slut for Nick.

Nick got a gleam in his eye. "You know..." he began. He had an idea. He was going to dangle it.

My ears perked up like a dog's.

He shook his head. "Nah. No, I shouldn't."

"Nick."

He held up a hand. "Look man. Eat up. We gotta get moving. Just come along, you're an observer."

He could see I was teetering. I was still tethered to my own, former reality. The one in which my wife was a sweet little cupcake in conservative clothing, at home making our house nice for our eventual family. Pristine and practically virginal.

For *that* wife, I should have gone home a long time ago.

But Nick's mind held images and memories of another Lana.

The real Lana.

And I wanted those.

Nick knew that, and I knew that Nick knew that.

I just couldn't combat it.

"You're not *doing* anything," Nick argued, as if I'd mounted a defense. He finished off his wine. "Unless you want to." He looked at my steak, suddenly off his sales pitch and into my steak. "You eating that?"

Just as quickly, he was on to other things. "Honestly, you're doing me a favor. Brandy likes a lot of people watching. It isn't really my bag, personally, to have a guy there who's like, lurking, but, you know... whatever keeps them happy."

He sloshed some wine around and grinned at me, as if to say: *Women, amirite?*

Chapter Eight

I almost backed out.

In the hallway, headed to a suite. There was music behind the door, and Brandy's skittish laughter shook me from my hypnotic trance.

My feet planted in the thick corridor carpet. "Nick, I, uh..." I shook my head, put my hands in my pockets, and started to turn my feet back the other way. "I need to get home. This is..."

I gave a glance, both of longing and fear, at the door.

Nick clapped a hand on my shoulder and pulled me forcefully back toward him. His fingers worked into my bones. He's a large guy, athletic and fit as fuck. He was exceptionally strong. "Listen to me. Okay? Brandy wants this, Chad. Which means I want it. Okay?"

"I shouldn't be here."

He shook me playfully, but it hurt a little. "Chad. Crobs. Listen to me. You're just going to sit down and watch my girlfriend suck a huge cock. She does this thing where -"

"Uh," I said, trying to peel Nick's hand off my shoulder. I thought about how Lana hadn't even texted me again yet. Unease rolled in my gut.

Was this cheating? If I didn't touch anything? How was it different than porn in that case?

As if reading my mind, Nick said, "It's just like porn." He was unlocking the door. Brandy was cooing at the sound.

Nick felt my hesitation. He turned his face to me and his fingers pressed into my formerly broken collarbone, which still overreacted to the

possibility of pain. "Do this for me, buddy."

"Nick-"

He pulled my head toward him, his fingers in my hair, tightly holding me. "You wanted to know about Lana, right?"

This is why Nick is running his own business.

Brandy was at the door now, asking if we were coming in, tugging on the handle. Giggling, talking to someone else behind the door as well.

Nick released me, grinning, and went in, his whole body turned toward me. A grin was on his face. "Just imagine it's Lana, Crobs. Try it. And then I'll never say another word."

"Chad," Brandy purred. She was in a red, see-through lingerie dress and thigh-high stockings with thick red lace hems. She had a Brazilian wax and a glimmer of jewelry between her legs. High, red heels. Her bountiful breasts jiggled beneath the gauzy fabric, and large, long, hardened nipples poked at the material. The mild imperfections of her body - a mole on her left hip, a slight thickness in her waist - peeked at me alluringly. They signaled that she was not a phantom, not an AI creation, not a porn star I would never meet.

She was very, very real, and very, very much asking me to come into a room and watch her fuck someone.

Her hand, full of glossy red nails, reached toward me. I held my hands up, muttering something like, "No touching," while she patted my chest.

She exchanged a sinister look with Nick. "Suit yourself," she said, turning to show me her bare ass through the swishing dress. She glanced over her shoulder. "You can always change your mind."

Nick guided me by my shoulders, rubbing them painfully, into the room. Brandy was approaching a bare-chested man. "Okay now we can start," she was saying.

The man barely looked over at us before his eyes returned to Brandy. Nick shoved me onto a small couch that looked like it had been shifted around. "I'll make you a drink."

"Who's this guy?" the man with Brandy was saying. He didn't seem to care. He was touching her neck, moving his fingers down, between her breasts. Nick was casually looking in the cupboards for drink mixers and glasses, as if we were about to start a finance meeting. "Ice?" he asked me.

"That's just Chad," Brandy was telling the man. He was the muscular, darker-skinned man from her phone. The one she had found so tasty. My

eyes went briefly to his package: it was swelling beneath his unbuttoned jeans and looked to have been true advertising. Brandy was touching his chest, playfully lingering on his nipples. "He's new to this."

"I'm just watching," I clarified. Nick laughed to himself and continued pouring drinks. I momentarily felt like I was back in middle school. Brandy let out a little laugh, but her man no longer cared who I was or what I intended to do. He was absorbed by Brandy now.

"I'm down with whatever," the man said. And who could blame him? Brandy was exceptionally hot, and she was a sure thing, and none of this looked like it was anyone's first rodeo but mine.

Nick had two whiskeys in his hands and strolled casually next to me to deliver one. I took it from him blindly, eyes on Brandy and the man. Now that I was here, and seated, what else was I going to do?

She tossed her hair and looked over at Nick. "What should we do?" Then her eyes shifted to me.

When I looked away, uncomfortable, she laughed. Nick sat down in a chair and sipped his drink.

Brandy lifted the dress off, tossing it over her head and shaking her hair out. Just like that. She was glorious in her near-nakedness. The thigh-highs and heels remained on, and she turned her body for everyone to get a look as she strolled casually to the bed and sat down on it, facing the man. Her legs were parted, wide, but I didn't have a good view of what was between them.

"I want to suck your cock," Brandy said, beckoning him with one of her long fingernails. "But only come if you can do it again in my pussy. Remember?"

He seemed to remember. This wasn't his first time, I could tell that much. Everyone in the room looked supremely comfortable, eyes on Brandy, mind on Brandy's pussy and her desire to have cum in it. My own eyes were free to roam wherever I wanted, because Brandy was looking at the huge cock springing from the unzipped jeans of the man in front of her, and Nick was looking at Brandy.

"Mmmm," she said, reaching for it, once the huge dick was loosed from the confines of the jeans. She reached out and wrapped her hand around it, pulling him closer to her. He had to step forward as she brought it closer to her mouth.

Then Brandy looked over at Nick, the crown of the dark member hovering just inches from her lips. She smiled, and Nick sucked in his breath, a look of concentration in his eyes that I had only seen if stocks were crashing or shooting for the moon.

She smiled. And then she turned and fluttered her eyes up at the owner of that cock, before pulling it into her mouth.

It's difficult to describe what happened in my psyche in the next few minutes. Part of me was very, very much in the room still. I had never in my life openly watched other people having sex (hearing it happen, sweating beneath a comforter on someone's floor at a college party, is not the same).

As Brandy's mouth moved along the turgid length of this man's cock, the sound of her spit and gentle gagging reached me as it cannot in mere video. Sharper crackles reached my ears, as her lips rolled up and down his shaft, crinkling the saliva that lubricated her travels. The guttural, barely audible moan of the man when she reached the base, the sputter of air escaping her mouth and nostrils as she struggled to breathe between strokes. The sounds bounced and collided, mixing in new ways.

The smell of sex began to make the air heavy and humid, reeking of taboos. The proximity of Nick, who I maintained studiously in my peripheral vision, pressed a deep humiliation tinged with something inexplicably fraternal into my muscles, and I tensed so much I would later feel muscle pains in my arms and back.

But I was also out of the room, out of my body. Brandy was blonde and nothing like Lana, but my mind found it incredibly easy to superimpose my wife over her. With my fingers digging into the sofa armrest, my pulse banging away next to my eardrum, and my roaring blood muffling all sound but the gluck, gluck, gluck of Brandy's blowjob, I was watching, in a way, my own wife Lana.

I felt a perverted desire growing inside me. I wanted to hear Nick say that this was what Lana used to do for him. I wanted it to be true as much as I wanted it to be untrue, I realized, my stomach careening to my feet. Maybe I even wanted it to be true more than I wanted Nick to turn to me and say, "don't worry. Lana never did this."

Brandy ravenously devoured this man's cock. She swallowed it to the base, gripped it in her hand and swiped her tongue around the shaft in playful laps. She pulled away, panting, to squeeze his column and watch precum bead into a fat, pearly drop at the tip, and then turned her head to

look at Nick while she extended her tongue and flicked the cum into her open mouth. Veins - wrapped around the man's cock, on the underside of Brandy's tongue, in the man's wiry hands when he worked his fingers into her hair - protruded everywhere, ugly and fascinating.

The man groaned at one point, and his eyelids started to come together as his features went limp and rigid all at once, a sign easy to recognize as nearing orgasm. I stared at Brandy's head, bobbing rhythmically against his pelvis, imagining Lana's silky dark hair instead. When he groaned and pushed her to his crotch, looking down to watch her take his seed in her mouth, the image was so saturated by my imagination that my heart seemed to implode with the weight of what I was seeing.

Brandy let his cock slip from her mouth and tilted her head, swinging her hair as she turned to show the contents to Nick. I saw them also :seed, as Nick had called it, lurking in an innoculatory dose, nestled white and creamy in her closed throat.

Then she swallowed, and smiled.

But Brandy didn't stop there. She draped her body onto the bed alluringly. Showing athletic grace, she swung her legs high into the air as she spun herself onto the bed and spread herself open. Her hair cascaded onto the pillows and she brought a finger to her cum-stained mouth, grinning.

Between her legs, a piece of jewelry not unlike the one that Lana had kept stuffed in a closet somewhere and hidden from me all this time, glimmered in the folds of her pussy. I stared, taking in the map of how it worked: the heavier metal piece (inlaid with turquoise) rested over her clit somehow, like a medieval clitoral hood. The meat of her clitoris was exceptionally large, and squeezed in its state of arousal from the metal open end of the capsule, raw, pink, and pulsing. Two equally medieval-looking rings attached to this item in ways I could not immediately fathom stretched across her pussy entrance, holding the lips together, barring any entry.

Her fingers went to her pussy and she played lazily with the item and her clit while we all watched. The man was gently stroking his dick, shaking it a little, perhaps hopefully to re-invigorate himself immediately. He tipped his head. "Well, well, what do we have here?"

A glance at Nick, who smiled proudly.

"I'll take it off," Brandy said, her voice a sexy slur that echoed, clanging, in my hard balls. "If you make me come."

She tapped a red fingernail on her swollen, protruding clit.

He strolled to the foot of the bed, facing Brandy's open legs and the metal-encrusted trap of her pussy. She was wet: her pussy-lips glistened with a thick coating of her excitement.

I stared at the contraption, my mind easily generating the image with my wife's pussy bound by the same item. It was so easy - too easy -to imagine Lana's flesh instead of Brandy's, that Lana was the woman this man was going to make come with his tongue. A vicious pain roared in my chest and I felt like I would be sick for a moment.

He dragged her closer to him by the ankles, making her hoot with laughter, and got on his knees to oblige her. I stared at the movement of his jaw as he enclosed her contraption and her flesh in his mouth and began to go to work on her. I put Brandy's yellow hair and larger tits out of my mind, focusing only on the twisting of her legs, the rise and fall and excited squeaking of her breath and untethered vocal chords.

It was all too easy to believe, mentally and physically, that I was watching my own wife, like a window into her past, as another man sucked her clit through the metal trap and massaged it until she came.

Brandy arched her back and showed impressive abdominal strength when she did come, lifting her torso to grip his head and look down at him as he finished her off.

"You like that?" he asked her, rising to his feet. His cock was rigid again.

My eyes went to Nick in that moment. Maybe I wanted to see something in his face at that moment, some dark warning that I should heed, a torture that would wave me off this idea and this fantasy with its obvious self-hating pain. I saw instead a man whose interest was completely and totally consumed, whose pleasure was still rising and seemed to be miles from its peak. I saw a youthful, concentrated hunger that shone like a light behind his eyes.

Brandy had not said anything. She smiled, and giggled sexily. She slipped her fingers into her pussy and stroked her contraption. Her eyes were on the man's, sucking him in. Her tongue moved over her teeth and her lips, beckoning, screaming for him to fuck her.

"Baby," she purred. She was looking at the man who was fucking her, but her voice seemed to curve around his contours, and so it was as obvious to me as to the man and to Nick himself that Brandy was talking to Nick. Nick was already rising from his chair when she said, "Come and unlock this for me?"

I was the only one in the room, as far as I could tell, who experienced any shock or discomfort as Nick took the place of the man who had just eaten his woman out and before that spurted his cum in her mouth. They even exchanged a kind of bro-ish smile as Nick took his place and the man moved out of the way, stroking his dick.

"Oh!" Brandy complained, laughing and putting a hand to Nick's head when he dove face-first into her pussy.

I experienced whatever the opposite of an out-of-body experience is. The noise of Nick's mouth as he waded through Brandy's juices -brought from her depths by the tongue of another man - echoed in my ears. The sound summoned the taste of Lana's pussy, the scent of her honeyed juices, into my brain as an olfactory illusion. It was so lifelike that a tiny electrical message managed to push itself through the lucid dream that had fully enclosed my thoughts: *you may be*, the message told me calmly, *having a seizure*.

Brandy squealed and laughed and carried on, as Nick - seemingly - removed the rings with his tongue. "My pussy is so tender, baby, please!" Brandy said, twisting with excitement. Nick laughed and moved back, depositing two rings on his open palm with a wicked grin.

Brandy's eyes went to her lover's. Her lips curled into an inviting smile as she used her formidable core strength to lift her still-heeled feet and legs high and wide. Her pussy, freed from the restraints, had broken open into a red gash, gushing with semi-opaque cream.

The man moved in to take Nick's place, as Nick backed away, grinning, on his knees. He still held something metal between his teeth, and it flashed amid his feral smile as he backed up.

The man gave a perfunctory glance at Nick, over his shoulder. "You good with bareback, right?"

Brandy was running her hands over her legs, smiling. One thigh-high had rolled a little and started to slip down her left thigh. "I want you to fill my pussy up," she purred.

Nick shifted a little, to get a better a view. He remained on the floor. His attention was completely absorbed by what was happening on the bed. I had a fleeting thought that I could simply have walked out at that moment, loudly, and no one would have noticed.

The man climbed onto the bed and seized Brandy's legs, holding them up and spread. For a few moments he probed her with his cock, sliding through

her juices and over her clit, which was still encapsulated in the metal hood. I thought maybe he was missing, since his hands were holding her legs, but he did it enough to Brandy's delight that I realized he was just teasing us all.

When he sank into her cunt, the image of his dick stretching her open burned into my mind, fused with my fantasies of Lana. I was impaled by a knife of pain in my chest, and my cock strained against my clothing, throbbing with a heated urgency. As he began to fuck Brandy, who moved her hands to cup her own ass and wailed sexily, my eyes drifted briefly to the stain of precum spreading in my crotch.

They fucked like this for a while, and then Brandy initiated a violent turn and climbed on top of him. She rode him languidly at first, her head turned to Nick. She smiled and her breasts, obviously fake, rose with her torso as a unit, jiggling only when the man reached up and squeezed them or twisted her nipples. Her magnificent ass - as solid as her silicone tits - framed the plunging cock between the man's thighs. Bounce, bounce, bounce.

This went on for some time, and then Brandy began to whine in her feline purr of a voice. "I want something in my mouth."

The man obliged, reaching for her mouth and inserting his fingers. Brandy gripped his forearm and sucked on his index and pointer finger while she rocked on his pelvis. She became a wave of undulating sexual treats - her ass rolled out and then forward with her hips, her torso stretching and her breasts rising into an arc, then back again.

I stared, transfixed, feeding my own fantasy by focusing on her ass and the parts of her that didn't dent my illusions of Lana.

So I was unfocused when Nick looked up at me and said, "What do you think, Crops? She gives an amazing blowjob."

I froze, stunned. Brandy tossed her hair and smiled appealingly at me with her mouth of smeared lipstick, still rocking on the man's hips. "I really, really need something to suck on," she tempted me.

My eyes seemed to move around, out of my control. From Brandy's dirty mouth, temptation pouring dirtily from her lips. To *my boss* -Nick, my wife's ex-boyfriend - and his amused and expectant stare. Nick's eyes burned with the challenging, confrontational heat of a dominating man, urging me to give in to sharing his girlfriend.

To my ring finger, my wedding vows glaring at me auspiciously. To a veil that existed only in my own mind, where Lana, not Brandy, was asking for something to suck on while she ground her pussy all over the pelvis of a

stranger, his cock deep inside her. Like a mist, the image of her own chastity piercing floated across all of it.

My fantasy of Lana, and just the proximity of this very real, taboo sex act, had given me an erection the ferocity of which I had believed had long, long ago passed me by. My nerves screamed for release. It was right there, within my grasp, between the white teeth and plump lips of this raving slut.

I remained seated and silent. Long enough to make Nick laugh, shake his head, and rise to his feet. He turned his back to me and put a hand in Brandy's hair, and she eagerly lunged for his cock when he pulled it out. "Here you go, honey," Nick told her.

Nick looked over his shoulder at me, with a grin, his dick in Brandy's mouth. She sucked him off playfully, smiling at him, pausing to look down at her lover. When the man gripped her hips and began to hammer her, getting close to coming, she released Nick from her mouth and moved her hand along his shaft rapidly.

From what I could tell of the groans and the spurting cum that splashed across her cheek before she turned to catch in her mouth, both men came at approximately the same time. Brandy's tongue waggled in the air, attempting to catch the spurts of cum as she moved her mouth toward Nick's cock to gobble it down.

Finished, Nick stroked Brandy's hair as she licked him clean, gripping his dick in her hand. Then he staggered backward, naked, and collapsed next to me on the sofa, brimming with the glow of a tremendous orgasm.

Brandy spread her palms out on the ripped chest of the man beneath her. He was staring up at her with his mouth open, twitching with the remnants of his orgasm. She tossed her head back and laughed, then started to roll her hips again, gripping his meaty pecs in her fingers like she wanted to pull them up and shape them into handlebars.

Nick laughed. "She ain't done yet, man, you just gotta grin and bear it."

Brandy rocked herself to orgasm while Nick studied her face, his grin spreading as she became sweatier and wilder, mewling with abandon. Finally, she plopped hard on the man's cock and shuddered, her face turned up to the ceiling, mouth open.

When Brandy slid off the stranger, her skin moved over his lubricated by the sweat on their bodies. Her stockings had been rolled down a little, and the one that had already slipped when she mounted him was nearly to her knee, loose and wrinkled like a used condom. The smell of sex pervaded the

room. She tossed her head on the pillow and draped her arms and one leg over the man's heaving body.

Looking through her own fingers, which were walking tenderly across the man's chest, she met Nick's eyes. "That was hot, baby," she said, close to the man's neck and with a tap of her fingers.

To either man, it might have seemed she was saying it to him. But from my perspective, it was clearly for Nick.

I felt, very suddenly, like I didn't belong in the room. I had felt that way the entire time, but now it was acute and painfully uncomfortable. The three of them were fucked-out, at least half-naked, and content. I was clothed, unwilling, and so tightly coiled-up with unspent energy that I felt like a hum was coming off me. I was a buzzing light, a distant alarm, a caged animal.

And what was I thinking about?

My wife.

"I have to go," I said, leaning my torso forward to gather momentum to propel me out of the sofa. As if it was a sport, I reverted to my athletic tactics: envision yourself making the goal. I was standing up, repeating, "I have to go now. I shouldn't be here," like a zombie. I pictured my feet moving on the carpet, I ignored the turn of Brandy's head and the expression on her face.

"Aw, Crobs," Nick said, but lazily. He spread himself out as soon as I got off the sofa, his cock - still hard - towering between his legs. I kept moving toward the door. "Lana's already going to be pissed, man," he said, grinning.

Then, curiously, he lifted his thumb, as though to inspect it. He popped it into his mouth and sucked it loudly, emitting a wet pop that made Brandy's grin bigger. The man himself was staring at the ceiling, one hand lazily moving on Brandy's back.

"Chaaaaaaa-aaaad," Brandy said. She swung the leg that had been draped over the man wide open, in an arc, with her impressive dancer's grace. Her pussy was wide open, and my eyes were pulled to the scene against my will. Her gash oozed cum, and her fingers were making their way to the red, swollen mess. Amid it all, flashing like the eyes of a cat about to snare a mouse, was what remained of the piercing. "Don't you want to stay?"

My hand was on the door. I faced it, to block the images from my eyes. The veil of Lana, of Lana's pussy, of Lana's piercing, still hung like a haze in my subconscious. I opened the door and Brandy let out a peal of laughter. Nick's low voice said something about the fun not being over yet.

"I have to go," my voice said. I had been saying that over and over, and it was true. I said it now as an incantation. Maybe, like Dorothy, I would be taken home by repeating it enough.

The door, like all hotel doors, swung closed very slowly. Nick was talking about me, but the murmurs were too low to make sense. Brandy laughed again, a very particular kind of feminine laugh. The kind that dares, that invites, that makes men do stupid things to prove their manhood. It gripped me by the balls, and it was only the sudden slam of the hotel door that freed me.

I almost ran to the elevator. When the doors didn't immediately open, I fled to the stairs and down them with the fear of prey in a hunt, images and scents of pussy chasing me in a cold sweat.

I summoned an Uber after walking a block. People stared at me as I passed them, and edged away.

As I was calling the ride, a message from Nick appeared. A photo was attached. I ignored the words and the image, but they destroyed my concentration.

Buddy we're not done yet....

the preview read. The photo was of pussy: I could see that from the thumbnail-sized preview.

Brandy's pussy.

An Uber, thankfully, was coming from around the block. I ignored Nick's message and the subsequent pings, sweeping them away to deal with later. My mind was rattled. This had to be the first time in my life I hadn't been sucked in by a picture like that.

The driver was a chatty man with barely an accent. He was enthusiastic about my night, and what I had been doing.

I very nearly confessed to him: I wanted to, desperately, to unburden myself.

Instead, answered his question with a cryptic, "You would not believe it if I told you, man," and resisted the temptation of his eyes in the rear-view mirror, pleading with me for details.

In the end, I'm a great liar when the lies are professional, and a terrible liar to my friends and family.

As the Uber wound its way through the forking paths of my affluent neighborhood, it began to pour over me: Lana *would* eventually find out what I had done tonight. On a long enough timeline, all lies- even the

professional ones, the business ones, the perfectly legal ones - get found out, even when the liar is good. I'm in my mid-thirties, and already a few have come back around for me, and those were the professional lies.

My friends and family could sniff me out in hours, not years.

And I had a problem: I didn't want to tell Lana about any of this.

But before you go thinking it's because I was ashamed of what I'd done, or because I felt I had crossed a line, let me disabuse you of that. Those were noble reasons to confess my sins, and I wished that was what ate at me.

The real reason I wanted to keep this a secret from Lana was not because I had kind of cheated - Lana, after all, had kept her own secrets and that's what I could easily say to her if I ever got busted for this act of watching (and not touching, bravo me) Brandy as she got fucked.

I knew Lana's sense of fairness by now, and I took her professed reasons for not telling me about this past at her word. If this ever came out, Lana would be compelled to call it even... eventually. Or at least I believed I could make the case to her.

It wasn't that, though.

The reason I didn't want to tell Lana about this was because I was afraid that once I started talking about it, I would be unable to stop. If I told her what I had done, the act of speaking it aloud would make it more real. Sexier. More within my reach.

Like Nick had evidently been once upon a time, I would become obsessed with the idea of Lana doing this for me.

I thought of Lana, my wife of five years, who in all that time had never given me so much an inkling of this kind of behavior existing inside of her. It clearly wasn't what she wanted to be anymore. And she was the woman I married, the woman I'd been happy with all this time.

I didn't want to - I couldn't possibly - convey to her that I was even thinking about, let alone freshly obsessed with the idea of, her becoming someone else.

While I paid for the Uber, I was still undecided about what I would say.

Chapter Nine

It was eleven-thirty when I crept into the house, but I sensed immediately that Lana was home and still up. Lights had been flicked on as Lana made her way through the house and remained illuminated in patches: she had spent time in the living room, in the kitchen, in the room we shared as an office area - one she rarely did anything in.

I ceased sneaking and closed the door deliberately and more loudly than necessary.

Nothing happened immediately in the house: no slamming of a laptop or sudden patter of feet. I wasn't sure what I had expected, or why I felt aflutter of disappointment.

Likely, I had wanted Lana to be engaged in something illicit, paving the way for me to trade sins with her and possibly be forgiven.

I moved some envelopes around on the kitchen counter, where our mail was set and left to pile until it became annoying. Nothing important ever came in the mail, but after working in finance, I refused to throw anything away without shredding it. Lana, as a result, had left the task to me on a permanent basis, in one of those unspoken marital trades that felt more like a Mexican standoff than anything else.

I heard her footsteps, down the stairs, and my heart began to race again. In the Uber, I had embarked and re-embarked again on a mission to make a decision about tonight - to tell or not to tell Lana - and my thoughts derailed before they had a chance to leave the station.

I still didn't know what I would do.

Lana was wearing a thin white t-shirt and panties, and no bra. It is difficult to overstate how unlike her this was for Lana, of the conservative two-piece matching nightwear. It was cool already, so I would have expected Lana in short flannels.

The shirt was thin and clung to her curves, revealing the shape of her breasts, the contrast of her skin and her mocha nipples. It came to just below the lowest swoop of her mound, and a sliver of the satin of her panties peeked between her thighs. Her hair was loose but looked perfectly combed.

I had no idea how to interpret this, but as far as my dick went - the dick I needed to tame and calm down - it was a very problematic getup. It was overly sexy, and looked deliberate. And yet it also had plausible deniability: this was not the same thing as trouncing into the kitchen in lingerie and heels.

A tsunami of images from Brandy's lingerie and heels getup, and then live-action sequences from the evening, almost overwhelmed me.

My dick reacted predictably to all of this, throbbing and somehow getting even harder than it already was.

Lana put a hand on the door frame of the kitchen and stopped there, looking pretty and poised, and telling me nothing about her state of mind.

"How was your day?" she asked softly.

It wasn't like I didn't know it was coming, but the confrontation hit me, like a freight train. It roared and then I felt the impact: the moment was here.

I shrugged, buying myself some more time. "Good."

That was true. It had been a good day. The evening merited other adjectives, but Lana had only asked about my *day*.

She stepped into the kitchen. "You worked pretty late," she said, and I eyed her warily for some indication of whether or not she was trying to trap me in a lie. I remember, as she walked toward me, feeling my resolve crumble away, my mind get pulled from its ethical quandaries by the movement of her body beneath the shirt.

By the time she got to the counter, I was only thinking of sex and how to initiate it. All other thoughts had been overrun: my desire to have good communication, tell the truth, not upset her, not be obsessed, not lose out on a good thing, jealousy, guilt... all gone and subsumed beneath the raging, forceful insistence of my cock.

Lana got within inches of me, by walking toward me, her eyes shyly batting and her legs seemingly endless. Static actually seemed to come to life between us, and it crackled beneath my skin. The kind of static wasn't clear: it could have been anything.

I racked my brains for her last words, the ones I was supposed to respond to. *You worked pretty late.* Observation? Accusation? Request for more information? Agreeing to it, even if just by not correcting it, was a lie. And I still hadn't decided what path to take.

Lana was moving closer. I scrutinized her movements, her facial features. She didn't seem particularly *anything*. The pressure to decide whether to confess to her or to try and hide it forever roared between my temples.

She put her hand on my arm. "I've missed you these past couple of days," she told me. The sincerity in her voice barely registered. Only her touch did: it was like touching a match to the propane that was coursing through me. I lit up, my muscles on fire, my cock screaming at me to have sex with Lana, now, on the kitchen counter.

"Me, too," I heard myself saying, and inside, even though I was still raging with confusing lust, a part of me caved in on itself. I did miss Lana. I was sorry we'd had our disagreement, and I realized that one thing I really wanted was for none of this to have ever happened. For it to all float out to sea with all the other memories I set adrift.

In many, many ways, I wished I didn't know about any of this.

I caved to my sentimentality, to this soft underbelly of my mind. I moved closer to her, pulling her in toward me. I did it recklessly, almost like a sleepwalker who has ticked deeper into a dream after half-awakening. Who cared why Lana was dressed like that, or what she had done with her ex-boyfriend? What difference did it make?

She began to fold inside my arms, in a familiar pattern that preceded sex. Her breath against my neck drove me wild, and again Brandy's lewd blowjobs and gaping pussy rose like a tide in my mind. My cock reacted accordingly, flexing against Lana's thigh.

There was little doubt that she registered this: she cuddled for a moment with her lips close to my neck and then rolled her forehead against mine. We were both leaning against each other's foreheads, looking down between us, panting slightly, reduced to whispers. Her arms were around my neck. Her nipples were hard, reminding me of Brandy's, poking against a semi-transparent fabric and beckoning me to touch them.

"I'm sorry I didn't tell you about any of this," Lana said, her voice a husk that enclosed her characteristic sweetness. "My past. With Nick," she clarified.

This was what she was saying with her mouth. It sounded like the beginning of an apology, to be followed by a request to just forget about everything. *That* would have been the Lana I married.

Her body, though, was hot and seductive. Her hips moved invitingly, and in the throb of her pulse beneath her jawline, the slightest sweet scent rising to my nose, her rigid nipples screaming to be touched, there was something else inside her body.

Taken all together, the way sexual cues always come - she was horny as hell. This so matched what I was feeling that it was all too easy to narrate a story to myself: Lana was turned on by own sins, and I was turned on by mine. She meant what she said, and she also didn't: and I wanted to put it behind us, and I also didn't. We were both lying, and it was a simple dance in my male mind to convince myself that we were both agreeing to keep those lies to ourselves.

Who didn't think of something else, occasionally, while they fucked? Something they didn't want to share with the other person? You couldn't have honest, sincere, joining-of-the-souls sex every single time.

My hands went to her hips and then beneath the t-shirt while I laid out this buffet of fantasies and apologies for myself. Once my palms felt the bumps of her ribs and then the very soft fullness of the swoop of her breasts, I had swallowed it all and was only thinking of sex.

Lana leaned into it. She turned her mouth up to mine and left it open, inviting me to kiss her. I did it dirtily: my tongue pushed inside and sought hers, finding it easily because she was surprised. This didn't last long: soon she was pushing into my mouth, her hand at the back of my head.

My hands had spread out over her breasts and I squeezed them. Impatient, I ran them quickly up to her arms, and Lana followed this plan without me having to speak it: she lifted her arms and pulled away from the kiss so the shirt could be ripped over her head and tossed to the floor. I seized her breasts again and she went back in for another kiss.

I started to move her toward the counter. My plan was to lift her to it and pull her panties down, then sink to my knees and grip her thighs the way I was gripping her breasts - forcefully, possessively - before I dove into her pussy. The many clever ideas I had formed about how to search discretely

for what I for some reason wanted very much to see - the tell-tale pinpoints of scar tissue where the piercing holes had sealed - had flown from my head.

All I wanted now was to worship her pussy with my tongue, and make her come, and then fuck her like an animal on the counter-top until she came again. Whatever Lana had in her mind, and whatever I had in my mind as I did this meant little to me.

But Lana was the one who pulled away. She sank her teeth into my lower lip when she pulled away from the kiss, pulling it out and meeting my eyes with a look that made my blood... how to describe it? Run so hot it felt like ice water? Freeze instantly and feel like a burn?

It was a look Lana had never given me. Was it real, or was I imagining it, distorting it through the filter of my thoughts?

This was all stuff I would ponder later. My brain was robbed of all blood, and the only thoughts I was having were being pounded to death by the pressure in my cock.

Lana released my lip with a grin. But the heat in her eyes still burned.

It continued to burn, intense and foreign, as she kept them locked on mine and began to slide down to the floor in front of me. It took me a few seconds to process what I was seeing: Lana's tits from above, her wrists turning and her fingers working on my fly, and above it all her face, upturned to me, and her eyes above it all. Two dark orbs that cut like obsidian and hid everything behind them.

Because I was so hard, she had to glance briefly to extricate my cock. In that instant, the spell was broken, and a wave of doubts began to cast a shadow on me.

Her fingers wrapped around my shaft, obliterating that wave of doubt. The limpid blackness of her eyes once again fixated on mine, and my mouth fell open with a small pop in my jaw.

Lana was not the blow-job giving sort, I suppose it needs no explanation. She had done it, but never sober, and never with this kind of initiative or enthusiasm. It was something I'd always had to basically beg for, and I explained that to myself as a side-effect of Lana's sexually conservative personality.

So as she swept the pad of her thumb over my raw and aching crown, and her finger slipped in the fresh precum, I had a tiny flicker of doubt reach out

of my lust. It flared for a moment, but Lana's lips were open and moving closer and closer to where I desperately wanted them.

And then I was engulfed in her mouth. I stared down at her, one hand about a foot from her head, no idea where to put it. I steadied myself with the other on the counter.

My cock disappeared into Lana's throat slowly, and I fought to tamp down the many flames that flared up: Brandy's voice, Brandy's mouth, the piercing pieces on the flat of Nick's palm, an entirely fantastical image of Lana, riding the man in the hotel while taking Nick's cock into her mouth like this.

My orgasm, I knew, was not far behind any of this, but the point of no return blew past me, barely detected, like a street sign on the Autobahn. Cum was surging through my cock already by the time the message reached my consciousness.

Lana was staring up at me, her head moving back and forth. I dropped my hand to her hair and moved my mouth. "Lana, baby," I began. My fingers clasped some of her hair and feebly pulled at it. Of course I wanted to come in her mouth, my cock hot in the silky bath of her throat.

But Lana thwarted this plan, and took me all the way in. I had only a millisecond to think to myself that she didn't even gag with my cock all the way back there, except for a flutter of her muscles.

As my cum exploded in the back of her throat, she seemed unsurprised. She sucked harder, and refused to release me. She blinked slowly and drank my whole load, then very slowly allowed my cock to emerge. She rested down on her heels and looked up at me, smiling.

I was panting, shocked. Unable to say anything. Lana's eyes were still hungry, still staring me down. In that moment she was so unlike herself that she terrified me, but any woman crouched on the floor looking up at you with your cum in her belly is obviously terrifying but also safe.

Now that the release had come for me, and the raging heat that had built up since the hotel was turning into the warm glow of sexual fulfillment... I began to get paranoid. Lana gave me a simmering look, an expression very unlike any I'd seen before.

She had a look in her eyes that most approximated... Brandy. Playful, sexual, untameable. It was *hot*, don't get me wrong. But when you see this kind of libertine glow for the first time in the eyes of a woman you've been married to for half a decade, hot or not: you start to wonder things.

Especially if you have a guilty conscience.

I told myself, sternly and quietly, that I was the one feeling guilty, so I was the one being paranoid.

Lana wasn't helping matters. Getting on her knees on the kitchen floor to give me a blowjob, in the middle of the week? Now she was standing up, giving me that searing look... and turning around.

She glanced over her shoulder at me and walked away seductively.

"Are you coming?" she asked me. "I'm not quite done with you, yet."

Walking down the hall, following my mostly-naked wife (who never walked, let alone *stalked*) around the house like this, I had a few moments of clarity brought to me by the release from my wife's (also inconsistent with her personality) amazing cock-sucking.

Who is this person? was chief among the thoughts that I tried to have and complete, correctly before lust took over me again. Was Lana setting me up for something? Maybe she knew about Brandy and Nick. But how?

Wrong way, I told myself, as Lana glanced at me again.

Why did I see Brandy's slutty smile in her lips? Why was I reading things into my wife that weren't there?

Was my conscience too guilty to do this?

What did this version of Lana even expect? Should I just confess now?

"You know," Lana said, parading herself into the master bedroom, flicking the lights on as she went. She climbed onto the bed and got onto all fours, then lifted one hand to slide her fingers beneath the string of silken material suspending her panties. She tossed her hair over her shoulder and looked back at me. Her ankles crossed, and her pretty toes wriggled enticingly as she gave her feet a sexy, languid twist.

She shifted her weight to her other hand and pulled the other side of her panties down, baring her ass, tugging until the white panties - heavy in the center with her juices - were midway down her thighs.

Lana never posed for me like this. I wanted her to, but if I got her into this position, it was a fluke or too many glasses of wine. The outer lips of her pussy - which she keeps immaculately waxed, something she's always done - are long and plump, and embedded in her long shapely thighs, she was like a sexual fractal: long lined of lip-shaped flesh embedded in lip-shaped flesh embedded in lip-shaped flesh. Her thighs were shiny where they kissed just below the crease of her leg, and bright pinkness poked from her outer labia, beckoning me.

"...I've been thinking about getting fucked all day."

I was stunned. *Stunned*.

Lana didn't say things like "fucked." She didn't dirty-talk. She didn't give blowjobs and get on all fours for me.

She moved her ass in an appealing motion. Her right hand moved to her flank, resting so that her fingers pointed down to the fractals of pussy-shapes between her legs. Above her wet pussy, her tiny pink hole seduced my eye: we never went there (*I* never went there, because I didn't have the balls to ask Lana about it). More than once, I'd been tempted to press my thumb into the tightness as I fucked her, so I tended to divert my attention from the temptation.

But it was Lana who was doing it now. Lana's fingers wandered to her slick lips and gathered some of the wetness there - all the while looking at me over her shoulder, her mouth in an obscene grin.

I shifted my eyes from her mouth-lips and the faint, dangerous smile on them, to her fingers as they moved back to her asshole and swirled around the pink pucker, to her eyes, glimmering with... what? I didn't even know anymore.

Her fingers plunged into her pussy, her hand still twisted over her ass so she was cupping her own buttock. She began to perform a massage of her pussy that looked as if it had seen immense practice. A sound that I had never heard Lana make came from her throat.

I had no need to check in with my cock visually, but I did: to my amazement, it was elongating, filling back up, becoming hard as a rock again. I saw that Lana's eyes had followed mine, and they were locked on my dick.

I stepped forward. Lana slipped her fingers from her pussy and brought them to her mouth. She sucked her juices from them and fluttered her eyes at me with a gleam that under any other circumstances I would have labeled competitive.

I was moving toward the bed, my eyes wide, one thing on my mind. Sure, I was trying to have a rational thought or two: why was Lana so different, was I getting trapped into something, what the fuck was happening, should I confess to her that I was also thinking about her getting fucked all day - by another guy?

What had gotten *into* her?

But once my cock was inches from her pussy, so close that the air around my crown felt humid, I stopped thinking about any of that.

Lana was so wet that I slid right in. Encased in the melted, wet heat of her cunt I was temporarily devoid of thought.

But from that bliss, a chilling thought surfaced: was she also *looser*?

We hadn't had sex for days, and when that happened, she always felt a little tight. I liked the squeeze of her, the feeling that I was breaking into her flesh, the wet and sudden burst forth when her tight hole gave way.

Instead of all that, I was in up to the hilt of my cock, almost too fast.

Lana squirmed, moving her hips side-to-side. My hands went to her lower back and her hips to steady myself. She seemed to be moving to seek something she herself wanted - my dick to hit some place inside her that only she knew about.

Then she started to bump against me, insistently. The sheath of her liquid pussy tensed in places but was mostly a hot bath that generated almost no friction. Taken by surprise - by all of it - I remained on my knees, unable to move myself. Lana began to fuck *me*, banging against my pelvis in wet slops that echoed as the only sound in the room besides our ragged breath.

Slap,slap, slap. I looked down at my wet cock as she gobbled it up with her pussy and then it emerged between the high rounded flesh of her ass, before she slammed back against me. "Oh," Lana said,over and over again, getting more demanding with each utterance.

Her head turned back toward the headboard, and she really began to hammer against me. "Oh, like that, I want you to *fuck me*, fuck me hard," she began to murmur, then command.

I seized her hips, my mind still a blizzard of crazy thoughts and confusion. But if a woman asks you, then demands you, to fuck her really hard, you better get to it. I started to move my own hips, half of my brain still marveling at how wet she was.

She continued to say all kinds of things that Lana would never have - *had* never said before, except in my own fantasies. "Oh," she complained, "Fuck me *harder*!"

And at one point, as she seemed to grow impatient - this was after several minutes of me slamming into her as best I could, my hands on her hips, her own body moving and making the task difficult - I swear Lana said: "*Will you fuck me, Do- oh, fuck me, fuck me harder... Ch... Chad, baby, please!*"

Who knows? With the utterance of that single syllable - or not - I went over the edge, and obeyed her command. As well as I could. I gripped her by the crease of her thighs and held her still, hammering into her until she began to shriek, and then dumping my own cum into her pussy with a loud yell.

Lana did something even stranger, then.

As I panted, easing myself down to my calves - the intention being to catch my breath and slide my cock from inside her pussy, maybe to watch the cum dribble for a moment while she remained there, however improbably, on display for me: Lana pushed herself back with me, resting her ass on my thighs.

My cock, now at half-mast, pushed its way out of her pussy like someone stretching out of a sweater they'd become entangled in. The meat flopped into her waiting hand. I shuddered and stared at the nubs of her spine, her hair sticking to my forehead, her sweaty body blocking my view of anything. She held the pulsing meat of my dick so that her hot, wet pussy lips still enclosed it, and her fingers strayed everywhere. On the underside of my dick, down to my balls, each motion sending a shudder through me.

Her head was tipped to her chin. She was *watching* it. Engrossed.

A chill was zipping along my nerves, and it came to rest at my neck, sending a wave of goosebumps all along the right side of my body - my neck, my shoulder, part of my rib cage.

Her panting, dirty talk came back to me, clanging like a bell. Had Lana just used Nick's name - 'Dom' - while she was fucking me like a banshee? Or was I imagining that?

Sure, she could have been about to say... "don't."

Maybe. But the vowel sounds of "Dom" and "don't" were completely different. And Lana had said (as far as I could remember) "dah."

Like Dominic. Not 'dough,' like the first part of "don't."

Or had she?

Doubts flooded me. Maybe I heard what I wanted to hear. Or didn't want to hear.

But I *wasn't* imaging what had just happened.

I knew that.

I nudged Lana as gently as I could, lifting my left thigh, to get her to move. She sort of slithered to the side, her skin wet and gliding over mine. Her ass was slippery with cum, the air damp with sex and sweat. As she

moved to the side of me, I caught her face in the light- upturned, rosy-cheeked, a smile on her lips.

A look of satisfaction that destroyed me, because I had never seen her look quite like this. Or quite this distant.

I gathered her up, messily, and deposited her on her back on the bed. She kept her legs curled up to her chest for a moment and then stretched them out, her eyes glazed over.

I rested on my arm and stretched out next to her. I was searching her face for something: an explanation, I guess. A blush of shame when she remembered that she'd almost said "Dom" while fucking me, her husband. *Chad*. All I got was a knife of arousal as she brought her fingers absent-mindedly to her mouth, and her eyelids grew heavy.

"Ohhhhhh," she purred. "That was nice."

Nice?

"I thought it was pretty hot," I told her, kissing her shoulder.

Her eyes - until that moment sort of drifting closed, each blink lasting longer, each lid opening less - flew open. She was looking at the ceiling, but I could see that behind her eyes, Lana was thinking much more intently than she had been moments before.

She rolled toward me, curling her arms together and getting her face close to my chest, like she usually did. Her eyes were still open, though, and her fingers were active, stroking my chest hair. Her perfect teeth dragged through the pink of her lower lip and then let it go.

"Chad?" she asked, looking into my chest.

I murmured "uh-hmm," assessing that I would be unable to say anything much without sticking my foot in my mouth. My heart was starting to pound: Lana's demeanor now seemed confessional.

"Was that... like, okay?"

Her eyes fluttered up to mine, and in them genuine concern seemed to actually burn.

Sometimes...women. Honestly. Was it 'okay' that I just sucked your cock and then asked you to fuck another load of cum into me?

That was all I thought, at first.

"Lana," I half-laughed, working my fingers toward the back of her head and pulling her toward me to kiss her forehead. "Are you joking?"

Lana's eyes flashed with a tiny bit of annoyance, but this passed quickly. She shrugged from the confines of my arms. Then looked up at my

eyes again. She pushed away to get a good look at me, scooting on her shoulder to put about twelve inches between us.

Her fingers were still playing with the hair on my chest. "I have to confess something," she said quietly.

Then she looked back to me.

"Ever since seeing Do - uh, Nick - again... I've been... I don't know. Just thinking about things."

I waited, because this preamble had sent my heartbeat through the roof, and a surge of arousal was making my cock fill again with lust. Anxiety, though - bilious, cold, nausea-inducing - was creeping into my whole body. My heart was enclosed by the slimy cold of it.

But she didn't say anything else.

I sat up and turned to look at her. "Thinking about things?" I asked, breathlessly.

Lana's arm shot to my bicep. She was suddenly all smiles. Laughing at me, almost. It only burned more.

"Not thinking about... *things*," Lana said, lightheartedly. She squeezed me. "Not like *that*." She started walking her fingers all over my skin, her thoughts seeming yet again to drift. "Just thinking maybe..."

She let out a huge sigh. Shrugged. "Maybe we could get a little more, you know, spice going."

"Like tonight?" These words left my mouth with a kind of frozen tonelessness. It was all I could muster. I was spinning into a zone of confusion that left me too disoriented to know what Lana would say next. Or why. Or what I should do when she did.

"Yeah," she said, looking into my armpit now - obviously, lost in thought, not enjoying the view - her fingers working their little circles of seduction on my chest. I collapsed down to face her on the pillow.

Lana retracted her playful hand and stuck both of them beneath her cheek. She met my eyes.

"Lana," I said seriously. "This was... hot. Really, really hot. So if this is what you had in mind... I mean, of course. Of course we can do this."

Now- after all of that - *now* a hot, red stain bloomed on Lana's cheeks and started to spread. Emotions seemed to rise to the surface of her face and play out, crashing into each other like waves in a pool, until her happy face morphed into one of distress.

"Lana?" I asked her, genuinely confused. I pushed her hair from her face and kissed her forehead. "Honey... I don't... get what... what are you upset about?"

She covered her face. Inhaled deeply. Then peeked out from behind her receding fingertips.

"I just... oh, I don't even know. I guess I just... I always worried that you would find out about me, find out about Dom and what..." her voice trailed off. "We did," she whispered.

"Honey-"

She reached to my wrist and squeezed it, cutting me off. "Just let me finish. I really want to be the woman you want me to be, and I really thought..." she let a sigh escape her. "I thought, if I just played it safe, then... and it was all fine, it was all fine until Dom - Nick - turned out to be... And then I just got too, too, too... I don't know!" She balled up her fists and shook a little. She looked me in the eyes, the red stain of her humiliation receding. "It just gets a hold of me, you know? And I feel so out of control."

"Out of control?" I said, alarmed in some ways, hopeful in others, a warning light blinking in the corner of my eyes.

"Out of control" was, of course, the last phrase I would have used to describe my wife.

Six weeks ago, anyway.

I still wouldn't describe her that way - but the idea of it seemed less preposterous now.

Also, as you, dear reader may have already intuited, no better opening was going to come my way to admit to Lana what I had done that evening.

But lurid curiosity won out. "Out of control, how?" I pressed her.

Lana folded her fingers together, her face now set into one of determination. She had something to say, and she was going to get it out.

"You know how I told you that, uh... Do - *Nick* - was the one, the one who, uh... he was too obsessed with... everything... and so I broke up with him. Because of that?"

"Yeah," I said, my voice feigning gameness.

But the cold, hard reality of what Lana was about to say was already hitting me like I had taken a belly-flop onto solid ice. I actually felt the tingling of my sinus cavities building up like a charge, as if someone had hit me in the face. The green spangles of a near-loss of consciousness crept into my vision.

Lana said no more. She just fluttered her eyes toward mine, in them the heart of her confession.

A puzzle suddenly solved. All the pieces that had not fit together clicked into place, one after the other. A beastly, opportunistic thrill went through me: Lana was a sex-crazed maniac, a serial cheater, a woman who loved to fuck like a banshee.

How wonderful.

But chasing behind this brief moment of thrill was cold, steely horror:

Lana was a sex-crazed maniac, a serial cheater, a woman who loved to fuck like a banshee.

And she had, with Nick.

And *she* - Lana, not Nick - Lana, my sweet, conservative-dressing, missionary-position-loving, faithful, doting, cupcake of a wife; not *Nick*, my coked-up, sleazy, alpha-male, dick-swinging boss - had been *out of control*.

Also- and do not think for a moment that I had lost sight of this - I had just done something very, very bad with Nick and Brandy. *Before* this confession, so I didn't have the right to claim fair game.

I felt, actually, really, quite fucking sick for a second.

I sat up rapidly, heat flaring on the back of my neck - the heat of extreme nausea. I could feel vomit making an attempt to rise in the back of my throat.

I held it in, or it went away. I looked down at Lana, who was looking hurt and confused. I could see water welling up in her eyes. They were big and damp, almost woeful.

"I'm not like that anymore," Lana told me. She put a hand out to my arm. "I promise."

I was too stunned to say anything.

Lana's eyes started to close. She was about to cry.

I fell back into bed with a huff - only because I needed to exhale. I pulled Lana close to me, quickly, so her head was resting in my shoulder, on the tender collarbone, which began to emit a low-level pain that usually only came with winter.

I ignored it.

"Chad," she said, and her breath skittered electrically across my chest. "Please say something."

"Lana...I don't know what to - so it was you? You all along? Did you break up with Nick because he was obsessed, like you said? Or because..."

Lana had been turning her head to face up to me as I spoke, and now she was looking into my eyes. Shame burned in hers, and a longing. I had hit the nail on the head.

"Can you still love me?" she said, suddenly, emotion overcoming her and turning her face into a display of so many emotions I would never have been able to guess which one dominated. "I only lied to you because I thought..." A sob ricocheted in her chest as she tried to keep it in.

A tunnel vision effect took over: I had several avenues here. One of them included addressing the evening I'd had, and now was as good of a time as any for me to admit to what I'd done. I could do that first, and then tell Lana that of course I *forgave* her...

Lana was still looking at me. I was under the gun. I needed to say something.

That all would have been fine.

But I had an itch inside me, now. Call it curiosity, obsession, manly filth, whatever nonsense Nick had been shilling at dinner... I wanted to phrase what I said next very carefully.

Not to make Lana feel bad: that was the last thing I wanted.

But to make sure that I wasn't going to say anything that would box me in. It was as if Lana had brought a plate of sweet-centered cookies to the table, warm from the oven, and *in theory* I needed to decline them politely.

Because these cookies, I could see, were very, very tasty. But very rich, and very likely poisoned.

"Lana, I love you," I told her.

My mind works fast. I found the words immediately after this anodyne(and true) statement.

"Nothing you've done - and nothing you ever do - will change that."

This was true, even if it hid other truths in its sweet contours. But then, so was Lana.

This filtered into her, and her wild facial expression morphed into something like relief.

Something else, though, wandered around in her eyes, twitched at the corners of her mouth. Secrets - the best and worst, the feminine kind - still lurked inside her. Doubt was like a haze nearly gone, still moving in the darkness of her gaze. Her lips were parted, but whatever she wanted to say

crouched at the back of her throat, either held back or afraid to leave the wet, warm cavity of her mouth.

"Also, Lana... I..."

It wasn't as if this all had to be resolved tonight, in this single sentence. Perhaps I would wake tomorrow and wish I had done with it all, and shut my mouth at the end of what I'd already said.

"It *was* really hot. Really, really hot."

I am not sure what I expected to happen when I said that. My intention had only been to leave the door open - for me. For a peek, maybe, once in a while, into the depths of Lana's depravity. Did I want a taste of it? Possibly. I was as afraid of it as I was seduced by it.

What played out on Lana's face, and in her body, were something else entirely.

Her eyes registered the remark and she seemed pleased.

And then, her eyes became uncoupled from what she was looking at, retreating to some hidden thought. A memory? An instinct? Desire? Calculation? I no longer knew, because I no longer trusted my instincts about Lana.

Lana herself remained in this miasma for only a moment, and then put a nail to her teeth and bit it tenderly, absently. Something moved across her face: a change of expression I knew well.

Reconsideration. No more, no less. The cool, detached recalculations of a man with too much money, who had come to the conclusion that his investment streams needed to be shifted.

I'd seen that before, after all.

Just never on a woman, never on this kind of portfolio.

She sighed the same way. A change of plan was being staked out behind her eyes. What plan, what change, what original course she was diverting, I couldn't know.

A smile. She moved her limbs and her body to squeeze against me and then release me.

"It was, wasn't it?"

I had forgotten, entirely, what she was responding to.

Lana's eyes grew heavy and fell closed over the course of silent minutes while I stared at the ceiling, wondering if the body-slam of this last statement had left Lana as awake as it had me.

When her mouth fell open a little and a very, very faint snore came from her nose, I had my answer.

Whatever I thought of Lana's guilt, or lack of control, or secret predilections, I knew one thing for sure: they did not keep her up at night, a cold sweat rolling in the creases of her limbs, tormenting her with the tension between the seductive heat of desire, and the risks its velvety darkness - the color of Lana's eyes - hid beneath its outward form.

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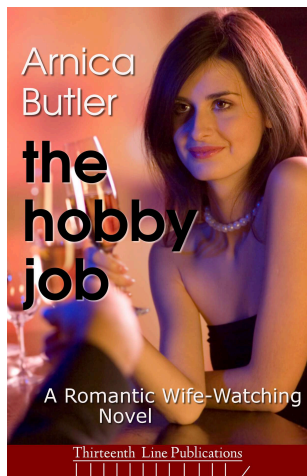
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